



AFTER CHRISTIANITY

GIANNI VATTIMO

TRANSLATED BY LUCA D'ISANTO

After Christianity

Italian Academy Lectures

Italian Academy Lectures



UMBERTO ECO

Serendipities: Language and Lunacy

CARLO GINZBURG

*No Island Is an Island: Four Glances at English Literature
in a World Perspective*

After Christianity



Gianni Vattimo

translated by Luca D'Isanto

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After Christianity

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INTRODUCTION



Believing That One Believes

THE ITALIAN TITLE of a recent book of mine, translated into English as *Belief*,¹ was *Credere di credere* (believing that one believes). It was a difficult title to translate, though it contained the meaning I wanted to convey in the text. The expression “believing that one believes” sounds paradoxical in Italian, too: to believe means having faith, conviction, or certainty in something, but also to opine—that is, to think with a certain degree of uncertainty. To clarify the title, then, I would say that the first *believing* has the latter meaning, while the second use of the term has the sense of having faith, conviction, and certainty. It is rather difficult to put the two meanings of the verb together: if I merely opine, if I think, I hold with some probability that I have certainty and faith. This sounds unclear as well as suspicious.

However, this expression’s meaning, unclear as it may be, seems to correspond to an experience that is widespread and comprehensible, and of which many of us are aware. As I say in my book, it came to mind one day while I was speaking on the telephone—indeed, on a public telephone

set in an open space, in the midst of traffic and of chatting people—with an old professor of philosophy who was also a fervent believer. I had not seen him for a long time, and he asked me whether I still believed in God. I answered, “Well, I believe that I believe.” This is still my attitude today. Upon reflecting on that spontaneous response I came to understand, or I believe to have understood, that this unclear meaning of faith is entirely bound up with my experience as a scholar of philosophy, and perhaps as an intellectual belonging to this specific epoch, too. I say this without any presumption. On the contrary, I recognize that what I hold to be “exemplary” is such only in the sense in which people generally call “an example” something corresponding to a number of similar objects, a car of a certain type, or a statistical sample (which has nothing exceptional about it either).

Why, then, do I think I have understood that for those like me who have any familiarity with contemporary philosophy, but above all with postmodern life, religious belief can only have this meaning characterized by a deep uncertainty of opinion?

My itinerary toward the Christian faith, too, makes me a statistical sample, of which quite a few people who have had training similar to mine also are part. After World War II, when I was about ten years old, I used to go to the parish church, where I developed my basic attitudes toward the world and others, including my social, political, and religious interests. Indeed, it was to live up to this blend of interests that I decided to study philosophy at the university: I wanted to contribute to the formation of a new Christian humanism, which would be free from liberal individualism and from collective and deterministic Marxism. Those were the years when we—the Catholic youth—studied the works of Jacques Maritain, a distinguished neo-Thomistic and antifascist French thinker, who had written a book entitled *Integral Humanism*. I inherited from Mar-

tain a diffidence toward certain dogmas of modernity. For this reason, after finishing my doctoral thesis on Aristotle, I became engrossed in the study of Nietzsche and Heidegger, who to me appeared to be the most radical critics of modernity. Now, it is precisely through these authors, who were not merely antimodern but also anti-Christian (especially Nietzsche), that I paradoxically was led back to the Christian faith, or to something that bears a striking resemblance to it.

Here I shall stop dwelling on my autobiography. Instead, I would like to explain my paradox of having recovered Christianity—in the form of believing that I believe—through Nietzsche and Heidegger. Nietzsche's announcement that "God is dead" is not an atheistic thesis like "God does not exist." Nietzsche could not state a thesis like the nonexistence of God because the claim to its absolute truth would have to be upheld as a metaphysical principle, that is, as the true "structure" of reality, having the same function as the traditional God of metaphysics. Wherever there is an absolute, even if it is the sheer affirmation of the nonexistence of God, metaphysics is always present in the form of the supreme principle, namely the God whose superfluousness Nietzsche believes to have discovered. In sum, for Nietzsche "God is dead" means nothing else than the fact that there is no ultimate foundation. An analogous meaning, albeit unacknowledged, is found in Heidegger's polemics against metaphysics—the whole European philosophical tradition from Parmenides on—which believes itself capable of grasping the ultimate foundation of reality in the form of an objective structure like an essence or a mathematical truth, which is given outside of time.

Just as Nietzsche cannot state that God does not exist (otherwise he would have to say that he knows the true structure of the real), Heidegger cannot dismiss metaphysics by stating that reality has a different structure, which is not objective but rather mobile. He would still be affirming

another structure. Indeed, Heidegger dismisses the metaphysical—objective, stable, and structural—conception of Being only in the name of an experience of freedom: if we exist (with our projects, hopes, aims, and fears) as finite beings who are not just appearance but rather beings who have a past and a future, then we cannot conceive of Being in accord with the objectivistic terms of metaphysics.

Actually, Heidegger's denial of metaphysics articulates the attitude of a large part not only of philosophical thought but also of artistic, literary, and religious thought at the beginning of the twentieth century, when humanistic culture began to feel the need to rebel against the total organization of society ("*die totale Verwaltung*" in Adorno), which had increasingly imposed itself through the rationalization of labor and the triumph of technology.

For much of twentieth-century philosophy it is no longer possible to think of Being as foundation, not simply because of the risk that objectivism might lead to a totalitarian society—to Auschwitz or to the Gulag—but above all because European culture has become aware that there are other cultures that cannot be merely classified as "primitive," that is, as lagging behind the West in the way of "progress." The 1800s were the century in which the historical sciences, including cultural anthropology, arose: there was a ripe awareness that there was not just a single course of history (culminating in Western civilization) but different cultures and different histories. This awareness would be decisively advanced through the wars of liberation of the colonial nations. Algeria's revolt against France as well as the petroleum war of the early 1970s were the last episodes within the theoretical, practical, and political rupture of Eurocentrism, i.e., of the idea of a unique human civilization of which Europe was conceived to be the leader as well as the apex.

How are all these themes—Nietzsche, Heidegger, the end of colonialism, and the Christian faith—related? It may

be possible to say that the epoch in which we live today, which is rightly called postmodern, is the epoch in which reality can no longer be conceived of as a structure solidly tied to a sole foundation that philosophy would have the task of knowing, or perhaps that religion would have the task of adoring. The pluralistic world in which we live cannot be interpreted by an ideology that wants to unify it at all costs in the name of a sole truth, which some academic disciplines would have the task and capacity of knowing. This ideology would stumble against, among other things, any ideals of democracy. It would affirm, as we have recently heard many Catholic politicians say, at least in Italy, that a law wanted by the majority but without truth (i.e., in contrast with the teachings of the Catholic Church) has no legitimacy. Hence, one must infer, it is a law that does not deserve to be obeyed.

Here one might proceed in different ways. For example, one might ask how we can rationally argue once we forgo the claim of grasping an ultimate foundation that would be valid for all, above and beyond any cultural differences. To this one might answer: the universal validity of an assertion can be construed by building consensus in dialogue, though without claiming any right in the name of an absolute truth. Dialogical consensus may be reached by acknowledging that we share a heritage of cultural, historical, and technological-scientific acquisitions.

Instead, here I intend to show how postmodern pluralism has enabled (for me, though I mean it in a more general sense) the recovery of the Christian faith. If God is dead, if philosophy has recognized that it cannot with certainty grasp the ultimate foundation, then philosophical atheism is no longer necessary. Only an absolute philosophy can feel the necessity of refuting religious experience. Yet, perhaps there is something more important in Nietzsche's announcement of the death of God. Nietzsche writes that God is dead because those who believe in him have

killed him. In other words, the faithful, who have learned not to lie because it was God's command, have discovered in the end that God himself is a superfluous lie. However, in light of our postmodern experience, this means: since God can no longer be upheld as an ultimate foundation, as the absolute metaphysical structure of the real, it is possible, once again, to believe in God. True, it is not the God of metaphysics or of medieval scholasticism. But that is not the God of the Bible, of the Book that was dissolved and dismissed by modern rationalist and absolutist metaphysics.

Furthermore, if there is no longer a philosophy (like Hegelian or Marxist historicism or like the various kinds of scientific positivism) claiming to be capable of demonstrating the nonexistence of God, we are free, again, to hear the words of Scripture. Moreover, in the postmodern end of the absolute philosophies, we become aware that once we discover that the vision of Being as eternal structure of objectivist metaphysics is untenable, we are left with the biblical notion of creation, namely with the contingency and historicity of our existing. To translate all this in secular and philosophical terms: it is above all because of the experience of postmodern pluralism that we can think of Being only as event, and of truth not as the reflection of reality's eternal structure but rather as a historical message that must be heard and to which we are called to respond. This conception of truth is not only valid for theology and philosophy. It is the same truth that, more or less explicitly, is upheld by a large part of the sciences, at least by those that have become aware of the historicity of their paradigms.

As is well known, this term has been characterized by its usage in Thomas Kuhn's *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* in 1963, whose meaning concerns us here. It is only based on certain presuppositions—methods, theorems, axioms, etc., which in turn are not verifiable or demonstrable or else one would go on *ad infinitum*—that the sciences

verify or falsify hypotheses. The rise and fall of scientific paradigms are complex historical events, which cannot be explained according to the logic of the proof and of confutation. What occurs in our everyday language also occurs within science: we experience things in the world only on the basis of forms that we have inherited, together with the other forms of our existence. For a long time, philosophers and linguists have dismissed the idea that first we see things and then attribute them their names. On the contrary, we encounter the world already possessing forms, words, grammatical structures through which we give it order, otherwise to us the world would appear to be an indistinct mess.

Here we don't need to develop further this mode of conceiving knowledge. I only intend to say that if we suppose, as I believe we should, that the postmodern conception of truth (understood as historical message, rise and fall of paradigms, interpretations of things in light of inherited historical languages) makes sense, it becomes possible to take the Bible seriously. Indeed, it becomes essential to take the Bible seriously, insofar as it is the principal book that has marked deeply the "paradigm" of Western culture. "Thank God, I am an atheist," says an Italian (not too) paradoxical expression. It is only as the heir of a Judeo-Christian tradition that conceives of the real in terms of creation and the history of salvation that postmodern thought has freed itself from the objectivistic metaphysics of scientism so that it can live up to its experience of cultural pluralism, namely of the historicity and contingency of existing.

Why, then, and in what sense, can one "believe that one believes"? The God I have recovered after liquidating metaphysics and the illusion that one could demonstrate that the real has a certain structure and a determinate foundation is not the God of metaphysical certainties, of the *preambula fidei*. The natural theology expressed by scholas-

tic metaphysics was grounded on the idea that a healthy, natural reason was capable of demonstrating the existence of a supreme Being—cause and *telos* of the world—so that one might then move on to hear revelation. Instead, the God recovered in the postmetaphysical and postmodern epoch is the God of the Book. This is not only in the subjective sense of the genitive—meaning God as the author of biblical revelation—but also in the objective sense of the genitive: the God who is given to us in the Book and who does not “exist” as an objective reality outside of salvation’s announcement, is always handed over in historically changing forms offered, in the sacred Scriptures and in the living tradition of the Church, to the continuing reinterpretation of the community of believers. It is not possible to “believe” in this God in the strong sense of the word, as if God’s reality were more demonstrable than the reality of sensate things or of the objects of physics and mathematics. “*Fides ex auditu*,” a motto that stems from the New Testament, also means that one believes in the God of revelation because one has “heard” about him. Hence it has all the uncertainty associated with all the things we take to be true because they are told by someone we trust, though it is a trust that has its precondition in the feeling of friendship, love, and respect. And we also know that “blind” love does not see things in their objective “truth.”

Yet if paradigms—the horizons through which we experience the world—are historical, existential, and transmitted, and therefore are not objects of demonstration or proof, this kind of believing is a primary and fundamental mode of encountering truth. In this sense, every authority comes from God: all verification and falsification of statements about the world is made possible by a foregrounding, albeit determining, faith that has the look of a conjecture, a risky wager, and ultimately a loving acceptance, devotion, and pietas.

This concept of postmodern faith has nothing to do

with the acceptance of strictly defined dogmas or with disciplines imposed by a single authority. The Church is certainly an important vehicle for revelation, but it is above all the community of believers who, in charity, hear and interpret freely the meaning of the Christian message, mutually helping and correcting one another. It is an idea of Church, found in many Romantic thinkers such as Novalis and Schleiermacher, that is wrongly treated as a utopia to be dismissed with the other theses of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century German idealism. Perhaps it is only by taking seriously this utopia that Christianity will be able to realize in the postmodern world its vocation as a universal religion.

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I



The God Who Is Dead

IN ONE OF the long fragments on nihilism from the 1800s (which was first published in *The Will to Power*), Nietzsche asks whether nihilism is compatible with some form of faith in the divine and conceives of the possibility of a pantheistic religiosity, since “after all only the moral God is denied”¹). After all, there are other, well-known passages in Nietzsche’s more mature work where he speaks of the creation of new gods. Let me remark that when announcing the death of God, Nietzsche anticipates that the latter’s shadow will continue to be cast upon our world for a long time. As with the emperor’s message in Kafka’s story, time is necessary so that the message will reach the most remote provinces of the empire, or the most secret corners of our consciousness. On the basis of these fragments, it is possible to draw not only the idea of the religious, Christian character of Nietzsche’s inspiration (on which there is an abundant literature, for example Karl Jaspers’s study) but also the impression that the announcement of the death of God does not definitely close off Nietzsche’s engagement with religion.

My aim here is not to explore the meaning of the possible “return” of religion in Nietzsche’s philosophy, which constitutes a problem (after all, still largely unresolved) for the Nietzsche-*Forschung*. Instead, I want to ask more generally whether and to what extent the end of all possible religious experience constitutes the implication of what Nietzsche calls the death of God (or the overcoming of the moral God), which in contemporary thought is described as the end of metaphysics.

I begin by explaining why I interpret the Nietzschean death of God as the end of metaphysics, which, as is well known, is Martin Heidegger’s idea. Here too I have no intention of providing a thematic or historical reconstruction of Heidegger’s thought. I argue instead that the Nietzschean announcement of the death of God and the Heideggerian announcement (let me stress the character of *announcement*: neither a theory nor a thesis) of the end of metaphysics can provide the general framework for characterizing late-modern experience. This is how I will discuss these thinkers (on the basis of historical analysis I have undertaken elsewhere).²

We are all aware of the meaning of Nietzsche’s announcement of the death of God. The belief in God was a powerful instrument of rationalization and discipline, which enabled man to leave the primitive state of the *bellum omnium contra omnes*, favoring the constitution of the “scientific” world view and paving the way for technology, with its reassuring effects that facilitate existence. For this reason, today’s “civilized” man no longer needs to believe in God. Now, those who were always commanded in the name of God not to lie have recognized that this belief is useless and obsolete. This is why Nietzsche argues that believers have killed God. However, this statement must be read beyond its literal meaning, in light of the general phenomenon of the lightening of existence brought about by the rationalization that was initially related to belief in

God. This phenomenon has made useless and obsolete the radical hypothesis concerning the existence of a supreme Being as the ground and ultimate *telos* of the world.

Let me stress that the Nietzschean doctrine has only the character of an announcement: Nietzsche is not putting forward an atheistic metaphysics, which would imply the claim to describe reality correctly as something from which God is excluded. This claim, like the claim advanced by the faith in the truth discussed in *The Gay Science*, would still entail a form of faith in the moral God as the founder and guarantor of the objective world order. Only if we keep this in mind can we recognize the analogy, or close continuity, between the Nietzschean doctrine of the death of God and the end of metaphysics of which Heidegger speaks. It is not a matter of discovering a philosophical truth superior to that of past metaphysical philosophies. Like the death of God, the end of metaphysics is an event that cannot be ascertained objectively, one to which thought is called to respond. It is an event that transforms the existence of the person who receives the announcement—or which is entirely constituted by this transformation.

In Heidegger's thought, the event of "the end of metaphysics" has basically the same meaning of the death of God: the moral God, in Nietzsche's view, is "*ueberwunden*," overcome, or put aside. Indeed, what Heidegger calls metaphysics is the belief in an objective world order, which must be recognized so that thought might conform with it its descriptions of reality and its moral choices. This belief in the objective world order evaporates when it is revealed to be untenable. Briefly, and provocatively, let me observe that this happens in the twentieth-century existentialism that is represented, more radically and more consistently, by Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927). Existentialism "corresponds" to the completion of metaphysics in the world of the incipient "total organization" of society, made pos-

sible by modern science, which has brought the premises of Greek metaphysics to their logical conclusion. Metaphysics endured only as long as it was a belief in the ideal world order—in a kingdom of essences that lay beyond empirical reality—which made knowledge and the critique of reality's limits possible. Now metaphysics has come to deny itself, through a chain of events associated with the development of the modern sciences, where the truth of the Platonic ideas has become more and more identifiable with the objectivity of the statements of physics. Metaphysics has unmasked itself as an untenable and inefficacious belief insofar as the ideal order, to which it always in principle related itself, has become the *de facto* order of the rationalized world of modern technological society. This order makes it *de facto* impossible to think of existence as project, opening, unpredictability, or ultimately as freedom. If true being lies in the objectivity of the objects ascertained by the sciences and codified by the laws of physics, then human existence cannot be conceived of as being and thereby becomes theoretically unthinkable. Heidegger's effort to move beyond metaphysics (which he describes as "the forgetting of being") into beings reflects the theoretical impossibility of thinking about human existence with the concepts inherited from tradition, as well as the practical—ethical and political—rebellion against what Adorno called the world of the total organization.

However, the self-dissolution of metaphysics cannot be described in these terms only. It is not confined to the view of being as objectivity, which has become untenable for theoretical and ethical-political reasons. After *Being and Time*, during the years that he himself described as the "turning" point of his thought, Heidegger increasingly insisted on the nihilistic outcomes of modern techno-science. However, in addition to the total organization of society, what refutes metaphysics, thereby making the belief in an objective, stable, and instituted order of being untenable,

is the inexorable proliferation of world “pictures.” The specialization of scientific languages, the proliferation of cultures (which are no longer hierarchically brought together under the Eurocentric myth of progress), the fragmentation of the life spheres, and the Babel-like pluralism of late-modern society have made the thought of a unified world order impossible to conceive. Now, all the meta-narratives—to use Lyotard’s well-taken expression—that claimed to mirror the objective structure of being have been discredited. Thus, the end of metaphysics is not merely the discovery, by a philosopher or by a school of thought, that Being is not the objectivity to which science has reduced it. It is above all associated with a series of events that have transformed our existence, of which post-metaphysical philosophy gives an interpretation rather than an objective description (an interpretation is not neutral but engaged knowledge, because it is not placed at an ideal point that would claim to be external to the process).

In other words, it is precisely the Babelic world of late modernity that “verifies” the Nietzschean announcement of the death of God and the Heideggerian announcement of the end of metaphysics—which are identical in meaning—by legitimizing them. In a certain sense, which cannot be systematized, this is the world where “the moral God” as metaphysical ground is dead and buried. But the moral God is only what Pascal referred to as the God of the philosophers. There are many indications, therefore, that the death of the moral God has paved the way for the renewal of religious life.

This seems clear, at least for me, in the realm of theory. The decline of metaphysics as a systematic philosophy, which conferred a consistent, unified, and rigorously grounded representation of the stable structures of Being, has made the philosophical denial of God’s existence impossible. This was, after all, already one of the principles Kant had set for himself in the *Critique of Pure Reason*. To

defend the possibility of religious experience, Kant had to show that reason couldn't speak objectively of God and of the *noumenal* world. Thus, he grounded religious experience on practical reason only, against efforts to deny it on the basis of metaphysical arguments. Today, it seems that the main philosophical outcome of the death of the metaphysical God and of the almost general discrediting of philosophical foundationalism is the renewed possibility of religious experience. This possibility returns to philosophy in the guise of the liberation of metaphor.

It seems, then, that Nietzsche may have been right in forecasting the invention of new gods. Narratives proliferate without any stable center or hierarchy in the Babel-like pluralism of late-modern society. No master narrative or normative metanarrative is any longer capable of legitimizing or delegitimizing them. The social hierarchy among languages, of which the young Nietzsche spoke in the long fragment "Truth and Lies in an Extra-moral Sense," has been overturned. In that fragment, Nietzsche asserted the metaphorical character of language: everybody associates freely a mental image with an object and a sound. Nietzsche illustrates how the obligation to "lie by following an instituted rule," that is, by adopting the master's metaphors as the only proper language, arose only through the institution of society and of a cast of masters. Consequently, the other languages were degraded to the realm of the poetic, namely to the status of purely metaphorical languages. But the pluralism without center of our postmetaphysical epoch has undermined the theoretical possibility of distinguishing between metaphorical and proper language. Wherever it survives, this distinction is revealed to be a pure effect of social power's unequal distribution. This was, for example, the sense of Michel Foucault's inquiry. To be sure, the liberation of metaphor from subordination to the proper sense has taken place in theory only. In practice, our pluralistic societies are still far from having

achieved the perfect equality of the life forms (different cultures, groups, minorities of different kinds) embodied in the different metaphorical systems. The demise of hierarchical principles and norms is, at least, sufficiently clear in the theoretical discourse of philosophy, literary criticism, and several genres of writing. We have at our disposal not only the explicit theory of the end of metanarratives advanced by Lyotard but also the theories of redescription such as Rorty's, who believes it is necessary for human culture to generate infinite redescriptions so that "the conversation might continue." A symptom of metaphor's liberation is visible in recent Italian philosophy and also in a lot of Continental philosophy in the flexible use, without any explicit justification, of mythological and religious terms. This began (following in Heidegger's footsteps) with philosophy's dialogue with poetry but went on as an autonomous phenomenon. Nowadays, it is more and more frequent for philosophers to speak of angels and redemption without providing an explicit justification for the use of these terms, or to refer to classical or preclassical mythologies extracted from the commentary of poetic, theological, or mythological texts. The distinction between philosophical and poetic—or creative—writing has been apparently erased.

The end of metaphysics and the death of the moral God have liquidated the philosophical basis of atheism. Contemporary philosophers seem to be mostly religious or irreligious as if out of inertia, rather than for strong theoretical reasons. In modernity, the theoretical reasons for being religious or not were associated with positivist or historicist metaphysics. God was denied either because his existence was not verifiable by scientific experiment or because he was a stage ineluctably overcome in the progressive enlightenment of reason. But the end of metaphysics has now discredited these metanarratives.

The revival of religion in late-industrial society cor-

responds, though without any direct causal link of dependence, to the liberation of metaphor and to the dismissal of the philosophical reasons of atheism. To be sure, many explanations have been advanced to explain this revival, which have to do in the end with the historical circumstances that have ushered in the end of metaphysics—for example, the demise of colonialism, which has *de facto* liberated “other” cultures, thereby making Eurocentric historicism itself impossible. The end of Western colonialism has also meant the possibility of developing a multiethnic society in most of the industrialized nations. Even though it has been less peaceful than the textual liberation of philosophy or of literary criticism, multiethnic pluralism can be treated as a phenomenon of the liberation of metaphor. The other cultures have made their voices heard in Western societies but have also brought with them their own theologies and religious beliefs. Perhaps the phenomenon of the rebirth of local religious traditions in Western societies is a mimetic and defensive reaction to this very pluralism. It is possible that the demise of proper language and of the hierarchy of world pictures has provoked a phenomenon of rejection, thus creating a need to return to some forms of belonging that are at the same time as reassuring and as dreadful as all forms of fatherhood. We may add to these phenomena, on the one hand, the popularity acquired by the Roman pope because of his contribution to the collapse of communist dictatorships; on the other hand, the seriousness of problems posed by developments in the life sciences, which cannot be resolved by the pure means of modern reason and thus may have driven people to seek deeper and “essential” truths.

I am sure that all of us could add to the list of reasons for the rebirth of religion and the forms that it is taking in our world. Now it is already possible to see, even in the brief outline drawn here, the configuration of a paradoxical situation: the return of religion, in all its theoretical, social,

and historical aspects (like the fall of Eurocentrism and the political liberation of other cultures), seems to depend on the dissolution of metaphysics, that is, on the dismissal of all doctrines, which claimed absolute and definitive values as the true description of Being's structures. Whereas the liberation of metaphor has allowed philosophers to speak of God, angels, and salvation once again, it is only the pluralism of late-modern societies that has conferred visibility to religion. In turn, though, the renewal of religion configures itself necessarily as the claim to an ultimate truth, which is indeed an object of faith rather than rational demonstration but which in the end tends to exclude the very pluralism of world pictures that has made it possible.

Once we acknowledge this paradox, we should ask whether the death of the moral-metaphysical God must necessarily lead us to the rebirth of the religious fundamentalism and of the ethnic-religious or religious-communitarian fundamentalism that are spreading around us. The same question, albeit slightly modified, can be raised at the philosophical level, too. It would seem paradoxical that the effect of the overcoming of metaphysics (which was theorized by Heidegger but also is central to a large part of twentieth-century philosophy) is the pure and simple legitimation of relativism and its shadow, fundamentalism, and communitarianism, its democratic version. Judging from the many signs, this is precisely what is happening—for example, Rorty's relativism and the communitarianism of philosophers like MacIntyre and Charles Taylor.

To return to the theme of religion, which is my topic here, it seems clear that the return of religion in the discourse of philosophy and in our shared experience has acquired visibility through the liberation of metaphor from subordination to the proper sense. But the condition of such liberation is entirely bound up with the end of metaphysics. I am thinking of Christian philosophers in contemporary Italian and French thought, who declare them-

selves to be “postmetaphysical” insofar as they treat the end of metaphysics as a process that has undermined philosophical atheism, paving the way for a Pascalian wager or decision of faith. The theses that I and other Italian post-Heideggerian philosophers have called “weak thought” have become very popular in a certain part of Italian Catholic thought because they have been interpreted, though with a degree of partiality, as a pure and simple confession of reason’s weakness. True, the demise of the metanarratives is a recognition of weakness in this sense; just as “weak” is Nietzsche’s recognition that one cannot avoid speaking metaphorically, that is, in a nonobjective and non-descriptive manner, without mirroring a state of affairs. However, this is just a small part of the whole picture. To extract it from the whole is to reduce the end of metaphysics and the death of the moral God to a pure and simple legitimization of relativism and fundamentalism, whether communitarian or not.

Once we acknowledge that, at the end of metaphysics, we have no ground for unmasking the truth hidden in our myths and ideologies because we have discovered that the belief in an ultimate truth is a myth and that the very idea of the unmasking of ideologies is itself an ideology, shall we just return to placing our faith in myths and ideologies? My impression is that this is precisely what is happening in many aspects of contemporary culture, even though it is not explicitly acknowledged. When, for instance, post-metaphysical philosophy limits itself to the defense of pluralism for its own sake or to the legitimization of proliferating narratives without hierarchy or center, it ends up preaching a pure and simple return to myth and ideology without setting up any critical principle, apart from the important principle of tolerance. Are not tolerance and pluralism themselves ultimately myths and ideologies, which cannot claim the status of normative metadiscourses? For anyone who acknowledges the impossibility of judging the

Babel-like pluralism of world pictures from an external point of view—a view from nowhere—the appeal to tolerance is insufficient. This, I believe, is the force of the communitarian objection to liberal relativism.

It seems, then, that only when we reflect on the difficulties emerging from the end of metaphysics and the death of God, philosophy meets religion, and not just as a possibility disclosed in “negative” fashion, that is, by recognizing philosophy’s defeat and weakness. The radical overcoming of metaphysics cannot be reduced to the pure and simple legitimization of myth, ideology, and the Pascalian leap of faith. Let me turn now to discussing Heidegger’s interpretation of the overcoming of metaphysics, since he is the philosopher who has theorized it more radically. The effort to think of Being—for the reasons mentioned at the outset—not as an objective structure projected by the mind to conform itself to in all its practical choices led Heidegger to practice philosophy as the recollection of the history of Being. The expression “history of Being” or “destiny of Being” (a word play on the German terms *Geschichte* and *Geschick*) is central to the later Heidegger. This is because, for Heidegger, only the thought that conceives of Being as event or as occurrence rather than objective structure is a nonmetaphysical and nonobjectifying way of recollecting Being. In other words, the objects of our experience are given only within a horizon; this horizon, like the light that makes things appear, is not in turn objectively visible. If we are capable of speaking of Being, we must conceive of Being as horizon and as light, rather than the general structure of objects. Since it is not an object, Being does not possess the stability assigned to it by the metaphysical tradition. Hence, the event of Being lies in the double sense of the genitive: the horizon is the opening belonging to Being, but it is also that to which Being itself belongs. Being is not given as a stable and eternal structure. Rather, Being gives itself, again and again, in its occurrence.

Heidegger believes that to think of Being as event means recollecting Being's history: for him, *Denken* is *andenken* (thinking is remembrance). This is not because, from the perspective of objective correspondence, it is necessary to know historical being in its totality—as Hegel ultimately argued. Rather, the point is “to take a leap in the liberating abyss of tradition.”³ It is a liberating leap because it shakes the claim of the order of beings to be held as the eternal and objective order of Being. The leap does not give us more truthful or more complete knowledge of what Being objectively is; it only tells us that Being is neither objective nor stable. Being manifests itself as an event with respect to which we are always engaged as interpreters somehow “on the way” (Being and man).

What I have proposed to call weak thought emphasizes this aspect of Heidegger's recollection: the leap in the abyss of tradition is also the weakening of Being, insofar as it shakes all claims to peremptoriness advanced by metaphysics's ontological structures. On the other hand, in the leap Being does not manifest itself abstractly as event—as if Being were “always” event, in accordance with a concept of historicity as the eternal finitude of existence or as the eternal fall into time. The *Ereignis* is an event that happens to us, here, today. Thus, the weakening generated when, in the leap, Being reveals itself as event is also, inseparably, a weakening understood as the sense and historical common thread of the tradition, onto which we leap. The recollective retracing of the history of Being is a philosophy of history, too, which is directed by the idea of weakening: i.e., consummation of strong structures on the theoretical level (from the metaphysical metanarrative to local rationality; from the belief in the objectivity of knowledge to the awareness of the hermeneutic character of truth) and on the level of individual and social existence (from the subject centered on the evidence of self-consciousness to psycho-

analysis's subject; from the despotic State to the constitutional State; and so on).

So far I have outlined two salient aspects of the death of God. I have shown how the end of metaphysics (the belief in an order of being as stable, necessary, and objectively knowable foundation) is accompanied in contemporary thought and social practice by the death of the moral God, namely the God of philosophers. The end of metaphysics, however, is also and above all the rebirth of the sacred in its many forms. For Heidegger, the end of metaphysics means moving from a conception of Being as structure to one of Being as event characterized by a tendency toward weakening.

The conclusions I want to draw from these two long premises are the following: first, the revival of religion in the postmetaphysical age is not exclusively the outcome of a misunderstanding. Rather, it can appear in its theoretical legitimacy if we recognize the deep family resemblance—at present I can refer to it only in this manner—between the Western religious tradition and the idea of Being as event with the destiny of weakening. Second, the recognition of this family resemblance offers philosophy the basis for a critical reflection on the forms that the sacred has taken in our time. Therefore, whenever it betrays its constitutive, antimetaphysical inspiration, the revival of religion must be subjected to philosophical criticism.

The recognition of the “family resemblance” is not realized “logically” as a conceptual necessity. As is often the case with most philosophical points of departure, it is somehow impure. However, it will be rationally legitimated on the basis of meanings, links, persuasiveness generated in the course of its development. If we ask why this vision of the history of Being as the destiny of weakening should be persuasive (as I, at least, believe), the following answer comes to mind: it is because we are the heirs of a tradition that has absorbed “Christian” values like broth-

erhood, charity, and nonviolence. This vision has its foundation in the idea of redemption (which already appears in the Old Testament) and in the idea of incarnation, the *kenosis* of God, as Saint Paul calls it. I am aware that these “humanitarian” values belonging to our tradition are the same ones that Nietzsche believed were the causes, and expressions, of nihilism and decadence. But Nietzsche, and above all Heidegger, also taught us that nihilism (and the democratic humanitarianism of our tradition) is the way in which metaphysics has come to closure and in which Being reveals itself, gives itself, as event. Postmetaphysical philosophy, which conceives of the history of Being as a destiny of weakening, cannot be separated from the tradition to which it belongs. Furthermore, to recognize this belonging is not to ascertain a phenomenon objectively.

As I mentioned above, this somehow reopens the philosophical debate on the end of metaphysics, and provides the basis for a critical evaluation of the forms in which the rebirth of the sacred appears in our time. The term around which these two aspects of my argument can be further developed is *secularization*. Having recognized its family resemblance with the biblical message of the history of salvation and with God’s incarnation, philosophy can call the weakening that it discovers as the characteristic feature of the history of Being secularization in its broadest sense, which comprises all the forms of dissolution of the sacred characteristic of the modern process of civilization. If it is the mode in which the weakening of Being realizes itself as the *kenosis* of God, which is the kernel of the history of salvation, secularization shall no longer be conceived of as abandonment of religion but as the paradoxical realization of Being’s religious vocation. From the perspective of secularization—of the vocation for weakening—postmetaphysical philosophy will understand and criticize the multifaceted phenomena of religion’s return in our culture, thus inescapably putting itself in question.

*The Teachings of Joachim of Fiore*

THE RECOGNITION THAT the history or weakening of Being is akin to the secularization of the sacred in the Western tradition discloses a broad area of reflection for philosophy, and for the self-interpretation of religious experience. My purpose in this chapter is not to reconsider, from the perspective of philosophy, philosophy's relationship to religion so that we might clarify the meaning of their family resemblance (as I have called it, leaving the meaning undefined), which is an important aspect of my reflection. Nor is it to discuss whether the recognition that secularized philosophy is akin to Christian revelation implies that the former has a duty to return purely and simply to the Bible, and eventually to the Church. This would amount to understanding secularization as an abandonment that needs to be revoked and put aside so that authenticity—the proper meaning of religious language—might be recovered. Instead, my intention is to trace the implications of the idea of secularization as a constitutive aspect of the history of Being, and therefore of the history of salvation, for our way of living the return of religion.

Nietzsche is right: the faithful have killed God. The death of God, of the moral-metaphysical God, is an effect of religiosity. In its most immediate and literal meaning, we might understand this statement in relation to the—not paradoxical—fact we have just seen: the dissolution of metaphysics generates an openness to religious experience in the philosophical thought, culture, and collective mentality of our society. It is possible that the renewed religious sensibility has killed metaphysics. But the charge that the faithful have killed God has an even more radical and perhaps scandalous significance; secularization, the departure from the sacred characteristics of Western modernity, is an occurrence within the history of Western religiosity. It is not alien and hostile toward Western religiosity but rather characterizes it very deeply. If modern civilization secularizes itself, this is the positive mode in which it responds to the announcement of the religious tradition. My argument here is that the radical meaning of this occurrence is that the religious experience that has incorporated itself into Western culture—the land of the sunset, as Heidegger calls it, though we might call it the land of the sunset of the sacred—constitutes the long “murder” of God, understood as a task that exemplifies the meaning of religion.

Joachim of Fiore offers us a model for living postmodern religious experience on the basis of the specific content of his teaching on the age of spirit and of his general theological tendency to understand salvation history as the story of the transformation in which the Scripture’s meaning is spiritualized. From his perspective, biblical revelation does not consist in the communication of a message that would have to be understood as faithfully and definitely as possible to be applied to existence. The promised salvation is above all an increasingly “fuller” and more perfect—rather than more literal or objective—understanding of the message. Salvation history is not just about those who receive the announcement. Rather, it is above all the history

of an announcement whose reception is its constitutive, rather than accidental, moment. Perhaps this is the essence of the Judeo-Christian message, which makes it a unique case in the history of religions and a reasonable candidate to be a universal religion—above and beyond imperialist or Eurocentric claims. The defense of universality cannot be reduced to the claim to speak the sole truth in contrast with the errors of false and mischievous gods. On the contrary, such a defense must present itself as a capacity for “assimilation,” understood not as a practical political adjustment (like the Roman Imperial Pantheon) but as the meaning of the doctrine of incarnation. Let me observe that many Catholic thinkers, such as Luigi Pareyson, who declare themselves to be strictly orthodox and who situate themselves in the perspective of postmetaphysical philosophy, do not suggest that the incarnation of God in Jesus Christ undermines—and delegitimizes—the myths of other religions; in many senses, they rather suggest that it implicitly validates them. Since the Christian God was incarnate in Jesus, we may also understand God through the other forms of natural being appearing in many non-Christian religious mythologies. Natural and historical symbols (up to the ciphers of which Jaspers speaks) can really symbolize God only because God has become a human being in Jesus, disclosing that he is akin to finitude and nature and—I would say—inaugurating the dissolution of divine transcendence.

However, the Christian tradition has understood only retrospectively the central dogma of incarnation’s capacity for assimilation, by showing the ultimate truth of Christ as the definitive fulfillment that closes the epoch of mythical and symbolic revelations. One might argue, then, that it is no longer possible to believe in myths. Indeed, myths are recognized to be true but are immediately “sublated” and overcome, following a scheme that is repeatedly used in Hegel’s philosophy of history. It is not by chance that He-

gel declares himself to be an authentic Christian author, and that he has been reproached for the anamnestic character of his thought. It is Joachim of Fiore, the medieval prophet of the so-called "third age" of salvation history, or the age of spirit, who emphasizes the openness to the future implicit in the dogma of incarnation. His theology of history has precedents in early Christian thought, too; for example, in Gregory of Nazianzus, who may well be his most important precursor. In the subsequent history of Christian thought, there is a broad crowd of conscious and unconscious followers of Joachim.

Joachim marks a decisive shift in the medieval exegesis of sacred Scripture insofar as he modifies and brings to completion the various theories of the multiple senses of Scripture. (The theory of the four senses of Scripture, which is the most famous, is found in Dante as well: literal, moral, allegorical, and anagogical; *littera gesta docet, quod credas allegoria, moralis quid agas, quo tendas anagogia*.) The theory of the four senses is known also as the doctrine of the spiritual intelligence of Scripture. Without denying these various aspects, Joachim places them in a more comprehensive or fundamental scheme, which can be rightly called "historical." The spiritual intelligence of Scripture is above all the capacity to grasp the events narrated in the Bible as "figures" of other historical events, rather than as parables aimed at the edification of the faithful. This means not only that the facts narrated in the Old Testament are read as figural symbols of New Testament events, as prophetic exegesis had already taught, though mainly for apologetic reasons (Jesus realized the prophecies, thereby legitimating them, and in turn was legitimated by them) or for the sake of edification. Joachim argues that his method enables one to prophesy in the proper sense by foretelling future events of salvation history on the basis of the figural exegesis of past events within the same history. I am not appealing to this prophetic aspect of Joachimite theology, which betrays

a literalism that contradicts the very idea of the age of spirit and risks lapsing to the level of Nostradamus. If by now we are, at least in principle, in the age of spiritual interpretation rather than the age of literal interpretation of sacred Scripture, it seems clearly a contradiction to demand that biblical narratives be read as narratives of events that are “objectively” true or as prophecies of events that are “really” destined to take place in world history. Eugenio Trias might be right in arguing that spirit can only unfold in a symbolic form, which leaves behind a concealed remnant and which by definition cannot be reduced to the literalism required by Joachim’s specific and realistic prophecies.¹ An event can never become the pure symbol of another discrete historical event. Spiritual interpretation cannot be reduced to a chronological displacement of the past to the future, or vice versa.

What I find interesting in Joachim’s teachings is the idea that salvation history is still in progress; in fact, we can speak of prophecies of the future only because salvation history remains unfulfilled. But for the same reason, prophecy cannot claim, without contradicting itself, to be realistically literal. For Joachim, the conviction that we live in the age of spirit in which the Bible can no longer be interpreted literally provides the only legitimation—apart from Jesus—of the prophetic interpretation of Scripture. This phenomenon, however, excludes literalism.

The three ages that make up Joachim’s scheme of history are relatively known. They are modeled on the three persons of the Trinity:

Three are the stages of the world indicated by the sacred texts. The first is the stage in which we have lived under the law; the second is that in which we live under grace; the third is one in which we shall live in a more perfect state of grace. . . . The first passed in slavery; the second is characterized

by filial slavery; the third will unfold in the name of freedom. The first is marked by awe, the second by faith, the third by charity. . . . The first period regards the slaves; the second regards the sons; the third regards the friends. . . . The first stage is ascribed to the Father, who is the author of all things; the second to the Son, who has been esteemed worthy to share our mud; the third to the Holy Spirit, of which the apostle says, "Where the spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom."

Moreover: "As the letter of the Old Testament appears to belong to the Father for its symbolism, and the letter of the New Testament to the Son, so the spiritual intelligence generated by both belongs to the Holy Spirit."²

For Joachim, we are clearly not yet in the third stage, that is, the age of spirit; but he prophesies it as imminent on the basis of figural correspondences with the events narrated in the Bible. The birth of Benedictine monasticism plays a determining role in these correspondences (which are too complex to be discussed here). Indeed, the third stage supposedly begins with the "time of Saint Benedict"; the order of the monks (after the order of the married and that of the preachers, corresponding respectively to the first and the second stage or age) "to which the great final period has been assigned belongs to the Holy Spirit" (*Expositio* f. 5 b-c). The monastic character of the third period is grounded on another aspect of the threefold division, according to which the first period is "distinguished by calamity, the second by action, and the third by contemplation" (*Concordia* 5:112 b-c).

The third age, therefore, is merely announced. Joachim's prophecy remains only a prophecy, namely a reading of the "signs of the times" that occur within the historical process. Yet he is able to read these signs because he is already, at least in part, living in the age whose imminence

he glimpses. This is not an unusual mode of reasoning in the history of religion: it is because salvation has already taken place that we are called to save ourselves. This, however, shows that salvation history is still in progress. If this scheme holds for all the religious announcements of salvation, its Christian form has the more radical implication because it concerns the content of the message and the mode in which the announcement is received by the faithful. The configuration of the history of creation and redemption as the articulation of the three ages "belonging" to the three persons of the Trinity introduces historical rhythm into the divine life, which constitutes the "content" of revelation.

So far, the meaning of Joachim's teachings for our discussion seems to lie in the "discovery" that historicity is constitutive of revelation. This historicity, in my view, corresponds to the "event" character of Being discovered by postmetaphysical philosophy. It is useless to stress, once again, that for philosophy this "discovery" has the same character of Joachim's prophecy of the third age. The end of metaphysics is an event that announces itself and demands to be recognized, promoted, and realized, or at least to be explicitly clarified as the guideline for our choices. The signs of the approaching third age, which today we call the end of metaphysics, are obviously not the same ones observed by Joachim. However, Joachim's text can still be our guide because of the general meaning of the age of spirit, which stresses not the letter but the spirit of revelation; no longer servants but friends; no longer awe or faith but charity; and perhaps also not action but contemplation. We could dare to think of the long process of secularization that separates us from the historical epoch of the abbot from Calabria as the realization of the conditions that are bringing us closer to the advent of the third age. We also cannot honestly say this age has been fulfilled. Perhaps, given its "spiritual" character, the third age cannot

be really conceived of as an actual fulfillment; however, this clearly raises significant dogmatic problems. The spirit breathes wherever it wants; its kingdom is one of freedom; and therefore one cannot establish definitive limits to it without reducing the spirit to the letter. However, this does not seem to challenge the kernel of Joachim's teaching, namely the idea that salvation takes place at a specific time—which is an intrinsically historical matter—and the idea that this history is still in progress, like the divine life that unfolds in the three persons of the Trinity.

The *Wirkung*, the reception of Joachim of Fiore's doctrines, constitutes this kernel throughout the history of European thought. De Lubac tells this history in a book³ whose importance is undeniable, although he is too constantly preoccupied with demonstrating the thesis, from the perspective of orthodox Catholicism, that the most radical aspects of Joachim's thought are untenable. To counter De Lubac's thesis, one could refer to the reading of Joachim proposed by Ernesto Buonaiuti, the great inspiration of Catholic modernism condemned by Pope Pius X at the beginning of the twentieth century. Many European thinkers, philosophers, and poets have been fascinated by Joachim's spiritual heritage, particularly by his idea of the essentially historical character of salvation, insofar as it is still in progress and involves the history of the world; therefore, it does not concern only the individual decision to assume the heritage of faith, taken once and for all. Among the "spiritual" posterity of Joachim, analysts like De Lubac, Novalis, Schleiermacher, and Schelling, are the thinkers who seem more in accord with the argument I am developing in this chapter. I am thinking not only of Schelling's *Philosophy of Mythology* (which I cannot discuss in depth) but also of his *Ältestes Systemprogramm des Deutschen Idealismus*, initially attributed to Hegel but actually created by Hegel, Schelling, and Hölderlin when they collaborated in Tübingen. The program announces with a prophetic tone

(let us acknowledge) the advent of the kingdom of freedom that will be realized only on the basis of a “sensible religion,” understood as the “monotheism of the heart, the polytheism of the imagination and of art,” and the “mythology of reason.” A more detailed analysis of this fragment could show the close proximity of this prophetic tone to Joachim. The program certainly takes up and emphasizes the idea of the spiritual interpretation of Scripture, as it speaks of “overturning all superstition, and persecution of the clergy” and predicts that the “blind awe of the people toward the wise and its priests” shall be no more. Although Joachim did not go that far, it is clear that after the demise of the age of the letter of Scripture and the realization of the kingdom of freedom and charity, the interpretation of sacred texts will no longer be the exclusive heritage of a priestly authority. Perhaps the aesthetic feature of the kingdom of freedom, appearing in the program, is closer to Joachim’s third stage insofar as it is an age of contemplation. Schelling writes: “Poetry will reach a superior dignity, it will become in the end what it was in the beginning—the teacher of humanity.” These points are even more explicitly made in Novalis’s essay “Christendom or Europe,” which was wrongly received, because of his radical Catholicism, as a “reactionary” text. The choice for Catholicism against Protestantism echoes Joachim’s tone to the extent that it is a choice against the strict literalism of the Bible. Luther introduced philology in the matter of faith through the principle of *sola Scriptura*, “whose wearing influence has been irresistible since then.”⁴ “Nothing destroyed religious feeling like the letter”; when, after Luther, “the absolute popularity of the Bible was asserted . . . the inadequate content, the rough, abstract sketch of religion in these books was all the more noticeably oppressive, and made it infinitely difficult for the Holy Spirit to bring about true vivification, penetration, and revelation” (Ibid.). Novalis believes that Romantic and Idealist Germany are the

precursors of a new religion, where “an infinite amount of intellectual spirit is being developed” (147), the announcement of “a great time of reconciliation, a savior who like a true genius will be at home among men, who can only be believed in and is not seen, and who is visible to the faithful in countless forms, consumed as bread and wine, embraced like a beloved woman, breathed as air, heard like word and song, and with heavenly delight, amid the pangs of love, taken up in the form of death into the innermost part of the body whose turbulence ceases at last” (148).

We are—perhaps luckily—no longer used to this visionary style. Rather, we tend to be suspicious of it because of its impact on German culture, the same culture that in the twentieth century has given birth to many political monsters. But the spirit breathes where it wants, and the Romantic dream of a new religion remains, albeit partially, our dream. Such a religion, as Novalis tells us at the end of the essay, must be founded on the ruins of the papacy and of sectarian Protestantism “and again form as a visible church without regard to national borders, one which will take up in its bosom all those souls who thirst for the supernatural, and gladly become the mediator between the old world and the new” (Ibid. 148). Joachim’s heritage is even more visible and explicit in Schleiermacher’s *Speeches on Religion*, in such theses as that the Bible should not be interpreted literally, because each religious spirit should be able to write one of its own. The *Speeches* belongs to the same epoch as Novalis’s essay, to the same cultural milieu, that of the *Athenaeum*, the journal of the Schlegel brothers.

Is it possible that Joachim’s presence within the modern European tradition—of which I have given just a few examples—might be close to the events characteristic of modernity that I have treated under the general title of secularization? I am trying to clarify and verify (I am not sure whether in this context one may speak of a proper proof, or of falsification) the hypothesis that the seculari-

zation of modern thought and society embraces the meaning of the end of metaphysics and the “discovery” of Being as event and destiny of weakening. Today, these are the signs of the age of spirit that could be compared to the central role played by Benedictine monasticism in Joachim’s scheme.

If we briefly come back to Novalis’s conclusion in the essay mentioned above, we see that there is a political or cosmopolitical modulation. Novalis’s hope for a new Church is fostered by the analysis of a series of historical events: the fall of the papacy brought about by the French Revolution (Novalis wrote the essay in 1799, when Rome had been occupied by the troops of Napoleon since 1798, sending Pius VI into exile to Valencia); and the crisis of the Protestant confessions, which were closed in their own sectarianism. Above all, Novalis had the impression that “the other continents are awaiting Europe’s reconciliation and resurrection so that they might follow and become citizens of the Kingdom of heaven” (Ibid. 151).

Perhaps we no longer face the crisis of the papacy or of the Protestant confessions. However, the ecumenical question seems as urgent as ever, not only as a theoretical problem of the Christian West’s relationship with other religions and with the societies reflected in them. What upsets, but at the same time makes concretely promising, the present world epoch is precisely religious and cultural pluralism. It would not be too daring to say that today the ecumenical feeling expressed in Novalis’s essay is driven by more concrete motives. It has shifted from the order of the dream and of individual poetic intuition to the everyday order of international politics. The determining factors that have brought about this transformation are largely socioeconomic; they depend on the outcome of unification and rationalization that technology has brought about in the lived world—the *ecumene*. The meaning of secularization illustrated here refers clearly to Max Weber’s descrip-

tion of modernity as the epoch of the capitalist rationalization of the world, grounded on a specific “application” of the Protestant ethic, and more generally of Judeo-Christian monotheism. To understand modernity as secularization, namely as the inner and “logical” development of the Judeo-Christian revelation, and to grasp the dissolution of metaphysics as the manifestation of Being as event, as its philosophical outcome, means to read the signs of the times, in the spirit of Joachim of Fiore and of his spiritual disciples such as Novalis, Schelling, and Schleiermacher.

If, in light of Joachim’s teachings, we interpret the death of the God who is killed by the faithful as the secularization upon which modernity has construed itself, then it acquires a meaning that takes up and completes, albeit transforms deeply, the way in which much of contemporary Christian theology speaks of secularization and of the death of God as events linked to the renewal of religion. In general, when it does not stigmatize secularization as an abandonment of the sacred or as a widespread sinful condition, theology recovers secularization only as the manifestation of the radical difference of God and earthly reality. This is the atmosphere of Karl Barth’s theology, though it is not always explicitly made in the doctrines: he understands the secularization of modern man as the paradoxical affirmation that God radically transcends any worldly realization. The secularized world is correlative to the wholly other. The same idea appears in Dietrich Bonhoeffer—in “religionless Christianity”—who dismisses the concept of God as a stopgap, namely the idea that God’s truth might be proved by emphasizing the inexorable insufficiency of man. To be sure, Bonhoeffer is closer than Barth to the “positive” concept of secularization, at least insofar as he explicitly dismisses a view of secularization as a paradox that reveals God’s transcendence. (This would be the metaphysical God, the stopgap and the supplement of human and worldly reality, which remains totally closed in the horizon

of finitude and sin.) However, neither Bonhoeffer nor—I suspect—other theologians of the death of God such as Cox, Altizer, Hamilton, and Van Buren has articulated an explicit theory of secularization and of the death of God as the positive affirmation of divinity based on the idea of incarnation. The presence of Nietzsche’s idea of the death of God in contemporary theology appears in doctrines that assume consciously the attitude of paradox. To be sure, I do not exclude the possibility that there might be exceptions (which would require a more detailed analysis). Contemporary thought emphasizes the disappearance of the sacred from the world precisely by affirming transcendence as the total “alterity” of the biblical God.

In a certain sense, the God who at the end of the secularization process is recovered as wholly other is the God of the Old Testament (let me say this without any anti-Semitic implication), and not the God incarnate in Jesus Christ, of the New Testament revelation, and even less the God understood as spirit in the third age prophesied by Joachim of Fiore. The reference to Joachim clearly shows the radical difference between the position I am illustrating here and the one more common in contemporary culture, which understands the recovery of religion only as openness to the wholly other. I am thinking of the widespread influence of Emmanuel Lévinas and of Derrida’s deconstruction. In Joachim’s terms, these positions go back to a theology of the first age, ignoring incarnation and consequently conceiving secularization as the fall in which God’s transcendence as the wholly other can be revealed through a dialectical reversal. God’s divinity would then consist in his radical alterity (for Derrida, the openness to the divine seems to have this meaning only: to say “*Viens*” to someone of whom we know absolutely nothing). The preference for Joachim against the theologies of the wholly other is not justified merely by the decision to remain faithful to the Christian tradition, as the historical tradition to which we

belong. This tradition—which addresses, appeals, commits, and binds us—comprises the Jewish heritage as well. It is only in the hardening of dogmatic systems and church disciplines that the two souls of our tradition—Judaism and Christianity—are separated from and juxtaposed to each other. The philosophical reasons, too, that lead us to recover religion—summed up as the manifestation of Being as the destiny of weakening at the end of metaphysics—oblige us to be suspicious of an excessive emphasis on the transcendence of God, as mystery, radical alterity, and paradox. Only the “leap” of faith, understood as the acceptance of absurdity, could correspond to that concept of God. In other words, God as the wholly other of which much of contemporary religious philosophy speaks is not the incarnate Christian God. It is the same old God of metaphysics, conceived of as the ultimate inaccessible ground of religion (to the point of appearing absurd) and warranted by his eminent objectivity, stability, and definitiveness—all traits belonging to the Platonic *ontos on*. If we were to follow contemporary theologies inspired by Barth and Bonhoeffer, conceiving of secularization as the locus where God is revealed in his radical transcendence, we would have to understand this process not so much as a leap or as an overturning, but as the fulfillment of the history of salvation, which is directed from the outset by the death of God as the dissolution of the sacred—the event Saint Paul calls *kenosis*. My interpretation of secularization is clearly inspired not only by Joachim of Fiore and Heidegger’s ontology but also by René Girard’s religious anthropology. In my view, Girard has persuasively demonstrated—for example, in *Violence and the Sacred*—that if a “divine” truth is given in Christianity, it is an unmasking of the violence that has given birth to the sacred of natural religion, that is, the sacred that is characteristic of the metaphysical God. God as the wholly other, toward which much contemporary philosophy inclines, retains too many

features of the “violent” God of natural religions. Transcendence, understood as inaccessibility to reason, paradox, and mystery, belongs to the “capricious God” of stupid and ferocious brutes who—according to Vico—worshipped and feared him in the *ingens sylva* because of thunder and other natural catastrophes to which they were continually exposed. By contrast, the God of Joachim’s age of spirit is not revealed in the mirror and enigma of these kinds of experiences. To be sure, Christ legitimated, through the event of incarnation, the many natural ciphers of the divine. However, for us these ciphers are valid only because they are the modes in which God descends from the heavens of transcendence, where primitive mentality had placed him, thus fulfilling the transition announced by the gospels, after which we shall be no longer called servants or (for Joachim) children, but friends.

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God the Ornament

WHAT ARE THE consequences of the fact that philosophy has recovered its provenance from the Judeo-Christian tradition, interpreted in light of the ontology of the event rather than of a metaphysical conception of Being? In the two preceding chapters, I have tried to establish, or at least to suggest, that on the basis of these two premises it is possible to construe an image of postmodern religious experience. I do not renounce using the word *postmodern*, because I am convinced that the history of salvation announced by the Bible realizes itself in world historical events—in this I remain faithful to Joachim’s teaching. But these events cannot merely signify the trial man has to undergo to gain eternal life or a condition of exile from which he must escape. My argument is that the history of salvation takes place through the events of modernity, and possibly of its crisis—since postmodern theories speak of the end of modernity and of the concept of history as unilinear progress. However, this end transforms into a paradoxical thesis the very idea of a postmodern religious experience, which goes back to Joachim of Fiore and to his theological “progressivism.”

Contemporary thought seems to find no place for this progressive conception of history. Karl Löwith, who illustrates the modern philosophy of history (up to Comte, Hegel, and Marx) as the secularizing interpretation of the Judeo-Christian idea of salvation, observes that this interpretation went into its deepest crisis with Nietzsche and his announcement of the eternal return. The reasons for this crisis, according to Löwith, are the same ones leveled by Kierkegaard at Hegel in the middle of the nineteenth century. Other reasons are associated with the explosion of the inner contradiction of historicism illustrated by Nietzsche in "The Uses and Abuses of History." We might also add that the widespread dismissal of historicism has to do more with the reasons given by Karl Popper, namely with the suspicion that faith in history as progress toward a condition of perfection might lead inescapably toward the political outcome of totalitarianism. This suspicion resounds in the negative character usually attributed to the word *millenarianism*, which is perhaps wrongly attached to the name of Joachim of Fiore. If salvation, paradise, and eternal perfection are conceived of as outcomes of the historical process realizable in this world, it is almost fated that a politics inspired by these beliefs would plan to establish by any means the perfect order, thus generating repressive regimes. If this were the case, then Hitler and communism would be placed along the trajectory of Joachim of Fiore's spiritual posterity, as in De Lubac's work mentioned above.

The idea of the divine as wholly other, which has inspired many religious philosophies in the second half of the twentieth century, has become very popular at a time of disillusionment with the revolutionary millenarianisms that have stained with bloodshed our most recent history. Post-modern theories are also the effects of this disillusionment: the catastrophic outcome of millenarian revolutions has undermined the "metanarratives" (Lyotard's term) that in-

spired them. But the end of the metanarratives that grounded modernity is not only the consequence of this catastrophe. These metanarratives have become unacceptable also because Eurocentrism has been undermined, like the historicism (i.e., positivism, idealism, Marxism) that inspired revolutionary millenarianism, in political practice. It would seem, then, that Joachim's metanarrative has become untenable as well. Thus, the only way of encountering religion at the end of historicist modernity would be that of Karl Barth and Emmanuel Lévinas, who speak of the divine as the "wholly other." I have already shown that, for philosophical reasons, this position is untenable, because it falls back on the metaphysics of Being as stable and eternal structure, given once and for all, which is inaccessible to rational discourse and therefore even more strictly "objective." Indeed, God could be conceived of as the wholly other, who in absolute transcendence overwhelms thought, only in these metaphysical terms. From the perspective of our Judeo-Christian heritage, the theologies of the wholly other do not seem to take too seriously the dogma of incarnation, even when they declare themselves to be Christian. By contrast, Joachim's theology of history is based on this dogma.

As I have argued elsewhere, if we interpret the end of modernity outside of objectivistic metaphysics, we may construe postmodern religious experience in light of Joachim's teachings. The way out of modernity cannot be found by retrieving the concept of Being as stable and eternal—suprahistorical structure—but rather by thinking, more radically, of Being as event. Being gives itself as an announcement or "sending," as Heidegger says, that comes from the tradition of which postmodern thought is the heir. There are good reasons to think that such a sending belongs to the history of salvation developed by Joachim of Fiore, insofar as it retains all the features of what Joachim called the beginning of the age of spirit.

Why call it “the age of spirit”? Joachim was led to do so by the demand for a reformation in the Church of his time, which he wanted to be less involved in earthly quarrels. To pave the way for salvation, the Church would have to constitute “one sheepfold under only one shepherd,” by converting all nations and above all the Jews to Christianity. For Joachim, the reformation of the Church hinged on a new spiritual interpretation of Scripture. It was “spiritual” in the sense that it was oriented toward the inner conversion of the human being and toward contemplation, and less involved in power struggles. Joachim, then, reread the Bible in light of the demand for moral and religious renewal in the Church of his time.

However, we have rediscovered Joachim’s teaching by starting from the thesis of the end of metaphysics, that is, the idea that Being announces itself as event and destiny of weakening. Philosophy, or at least a good part of it, has not autonomously “discovered” the end of metaphysics. If the observations I have made in the preceding chapters are true—i.e., that philosophy, today, conceives of Being as event and as destiny of weakening—there is every indication that the message of the Judeo-Christian heritage is still alive in philosophy. What happens to philosophy with the end of metaphysics also belongs to the history of salvation construed by Joachim as the moment of the “third age.” I have repeatedly said that I do not intend to follow Joachim of Fiore in his too literal, insufficiently “spiritual” effort to forecast future events on the basis of complex symbolic deciphering of scriptural texts. What seems still valid in his teaching, from the perspective of a postmetaphysical philosophy, is the idea that the history of salvation occurs today as the spiritualization of Christianity. What follows is an attempt, on the one hand, to clarify the relationship between spiritualization and weakening, and on the other hand, to show that in contemporary culture there are visi-

ble signs of a transformation that can be interpreted in this light.

These two steps cannot be taken in strict sequence. I have already alluded to the secularization characteristic of the modern world, in order to suggest that the weakening of Being of which postmetaphysical thought speaks is a spiritualization of the meaning of Scripture. If we look at the fundamental text for a description of modernity as secularization, namely Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, we see that capitalism's relationship to Christian ethics is one of interpretive application rather than abandonment or polemical opposition. According to Weber, modern capitalism can be understood only as the outcome of the ethical principles of Protestantism. This is the sense in which I employ the term *secularization*: it is an interpretive application of the biblical message that situates it beyond the strictly sacramental, sacral, or ecclesiastical realm. Whoever argues that this gesture betrays the biblical message obviously defends the literal interpretation of Christian doctrine, which, therefore, can be legitimately opposed by the idea of secularization as "spiritual" interpretation. Weber's model may well be extended to the whole relationship of modernity with the Bible, which, after all, has explicitly been the most eminent textbook for all Western interpretations of the world, from the perspective of politics to that of family life, up to the natural sciences (as, for example, in the case of Galileo's dispute over heliocentrism or in the debates about evolution). In the wake of the emancipatory struggles of modern reason, the Bible has played a less central role. However, the opposition between modern "enlightened" reason and religious faith seems to be nowadays a matter of the past, because awareness of "the dialectic of the Enlightenment" has radically limited the claim to dismiss religious belief on the basis of purely rational explanations of the world.

Christianity's encounters with other religions, which have freed themselves from the stigma of barbarism and primitivism that colonial missionaries had attributed to them, have radically reduced the claims of the Christian churches (most of all the Catholic Church) to be the repository of the sole true religion. In this atmosphere, which is dominant in our society, it is no longer possible to separate secular history from sacred history. Modernity seems to occur within the history of salvation—not only because capitalism stems from the Protestant ethic (and even before then, from the scientific vision of the world made possible by biblical monotheism) but for other constitutive reasons as well. It would be difficult to conceive of the democratic evolution of modern political forms apart from the Christian concept of the brotherhood of men as children of the One God: the rejection of war, inscribed in the charter of the United Nations, is at least in principle an effect of the deep influence of Christian or religious ideas. The distinction between the public and the private sphere of existence, too, has to do with religious experience, namely with the relationship between religion and mundane life.

The difficulties that have obstructed the recognition of the proximity or identity of secular history with sacred history may be easily traced back to the persistent prevalence of the “literal” interpretation of Scripture. A lay spirit might immediately reply to this argument that the Christian churches, above all the Catholic Church, have contested the accomplishments of modernity mentioned above, starting with the heliocentric hypothesis, up to the Democratic and Republican Constitutions. However, the well-known example of Galileo's condemnation shows that the Church's attitude was inspired by the literal—and therefore authoritarian—interpretation of the biblical text. When the Church nowadays condemns secularization in both individual and social life as abandonment and betrayal, it still appeals to the literal interpretation of Scrip-

ture. In certain cases, this is so obvious as to appear in all its absurdity: consider the interdiction of women's ordination, which is justified only by the fact that Jesus chose men as his apostles. Examples like this, which for good reasons are central to debates in many Catholic circles, show that literalism is based on specific links with a historically determined culture falsely assumed to be "nature." What did lead Jesus to choose men as apostles, and still leads to the interdiction of women's ordination in the Catholic Church, is women's social condition of inferiority. At the time of Christ this inferiority was widespread and taken for granted. Today it is just a vestige of the past that is assumed by the Catholic Church to be an eternal norm of nature consecrated by the actual choices of Jesus.

My argument is that our epoch must be treated as the age of the spiritual interpretation of the biblical message. The active presence of the Christian heritage is recognizable only if the literal, and authoritarian, interpretation of the Bible is abandoned. Let me insist on the example of women's ordination, because it is emblematic of our situation: there is no doubt that it is more Christian, for women, to desire to accede than to forgo the priesthood. This inclusion should be interpreted as the positive phenomenon of the extension of the priestly vocation. But the Catholic Church does not conceive of the priesthood in this way, because it is incapable of freeing itself from the letter, that is, from the history of the first apostles' appointment. Analogously, if literalism no longer holds sway in the reading of Scripture, we will be able to recognize the genuine history of salvation in many aspects of the modern world and of our actuality, which instead appear to a rigorously "orthodox" mentality to be abandonment of and breaking from religion. From this perspective, we should examine the spread of marginal, heterodox, and syncretistic religions in various parts of the late Western world. The official churches generally tend to condemn these religious

phenomena as aberrant or even as fraud, whereas perhaps they should be treated with more tolerance and more openness. In other words, once examined from the perspective of a more flexible interpretation of the Bible, most of the nonreligiousness in lay society and in marginal or spurious religiosity appears to have different aspects and values.

One might ask whether there are any limits to the acceptance of secularization. Is there any distinction between legitimate and aberrant interpretations of the Christian message? The criterion indicated by the Christian tradition, beginning with Saint Augustine, is “*ama et fac quod vis.*” Charity is the only limit to the spiritualization of the biblical message; the same principle characterizes Joachim’s third epoch of the history of salvation. It is not at all a generic or vague principle. Consider, again, the moral preaching of the Catholic Church: a sexual ethics that defines love as not confined to traditional family structures and not governed by the principle of reproduction does not clash with the commandment of charity. The ecclesiastical teaching, however, continues to oppose to charity a discipline that is entirely grounded on specific biblical texts (for example, the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah) and on a philosophically outdated metaphysics of “nature,” which amounts more or less to the Aristotelian doctrine of the “natural places.”

The spiritual reading of the biblical text, and more generally of the Christian dogma, is needed to recognize the pervasive religious essence of many aspects of secularized society and to enable the ecumenical dialogue of the Christian churches among themselves and with other religions. The recognition at the closure of colonialism that other cultures have equal rights, which was accomplished theoretically through the dissolution of Eurocentric meta-narratives, demands that Christians abandon their missionary attitude, that is, their claim to bring the sole truth to the pagan world. The recognition of other religions’

truth, which begins to happen for many Christian theologians (for example, I have in mind uncomfortable figures such as Hans Küng) requires an intense attempt at a spiritual reading of the Bible and of much dogma of the ecclesiastical tradition, to the point of disclosing the kernel of revelation, charity. The price to be paid for all this is a weakening of all claims to the literal validity of biblical texts and to the peremptoriness of the churches' dogmatic teaching.

However, here we are not concerned with a new reading of sacred history, namely with the destiny of Christianity and of the Christian churches. From our perspective, sacred and secular history are, at least in principle, no longer distinguishable. This is the first meaning of the family resemblance we have recognized between postmetaphysical philosophy and the Western religious tradition. The spiritualization I am illustrating (employing freely Joachim's term) is not exclusively linked to the problem of reading the biblical texts. It occurs in all the spheres of life as the postmodern outcome of modernization. Just as the spiritualization of the biblical text's meaning imposed itself upon the churches through the problem of meeting other religions, so the spiritualization of the sense of reality itself is brought about by the general effects of cultural, political, and social pluralism characteristic of our postmodern world. One of the most famous works of Paul Ricoeur is entitled *The Conflict of Interpretations*. This title, above and beyond Ricoeur's intention, can be useful for disclosing the essence of the postmodern world. The most radical version of hermeneutic philosophy, to which Ricoeur refers in this book, can be summed up with Nietzsche's statement: "There are no facts, only interpretations." Since we are aware—after Nietzsche and Heidegger—that every relation to the world is "mediated" (the epistemologists would say "theory laden") by cultural schemes, that is, by historical paradigms that are the true *a priori* of all knowledge,

we can no longer deceive ourselves (or worse, let ourselves be deceived) into thinking that what we say and what is said to us is an objective description of a reality that is given out there. The idea of a destiny of weakening somehow inscribed in the history of Being claims to interpret this specific situation: a reality understood not as the stable presence of things clearly defined in themselves that the mind can mirror objectively but as the play of interpretation is in many senses a diminished reality. If, as many contemporary philosophical positions argue, we understand truth not as the correspondence of the mind with the thing (the faithful description of a state of affairs) but instead as plausibility and persuasiveness that is linked to a set of premises (or to a community of competent speakers), we meet a phenomenon of weakening again. Furthermore, we could take the central role that the notion of consensus has assumed in contemporary philosophy, the very definition of truth, as an indication that charity has replaced the traditional conception of what truth means (see for example Davidson's use of the term *charity*).¹ This mode of characterizing postmodernity sees spiritualization as the meaning of the weakening of Being's strong structures due to the triumph of technology in our world. Technology, which in the beginning was just an engine technology, developed first a mechanical ability that lightened reality, thereby making manual labor less burdensome; today, computer technologies increasingly reduce reality to the play of interpretation. It would be too much to attempt to show that the first meaning of spiritualization—the more appropriately theological meaning realized in the spiritual reading of the Bible and of Christian dogma—is bound up with this more general process of reduction of the sense of reality. This link is slightly visible in the question of ecumenism, the relationship with other religions, which has to do with a more flexible reading of the sacred text that imposes itself on the churches precisely in the world of the communi-

cation technologies characterized by the conflict of interpretation.

When facing the task of reducing the weight of the biblical letter and dogma to understand the truth of other religions, Christian thought discovers that charity is the only thing that really matters. Indeed, charity is the only limit and criterion of the spiritual interpretation of Scripture. Analogously, if in the epoch of the end of metaphysics philosophical thought understands the history of Being as a destiny of weakening (i.e., in which reality is “reduced” to the conflict or play of interpretation), it takes this destiny as the only guiding thread to which it can refer to judge the plausibility of interpretation and to decide moral options. After Nietzsche, Freud, Marx, and Heidegger, there is no ultimate and indubitable metaphysical foundation in which we might put our trust; nor is the voice of Kantian reason, which would speak in all men in the same manner, given. Cultural anthropology has made us sensitive to the irreducible pluralism of cultures. To interpret the world and evaluate alternative ethics, we can only refer to the appeal that comes from the history in which we are always already involved. To be sure, it is an appeal that does not speak univocally but rather involves us as interpreters. True, the decision to interpret our provenance as moving toward weakening is already a way of explicitly assuming the Judeo-Christian heritage that we carry within us. This is also an interpretation, not a fact. Even the assumption of the heritage is an interpretation. Then what? We are ready to abandon this interpretation only if someone will propose a better one. But we will not abandon it on the basis of the “realistic” argument that it is “only” an interpretation.

I cannot draw in detail the ethical consequences of reading the history of Being as weakening. These are not limited to grounding the choice for tolerance. Rather, they foster an active commitment to diminish violence in all its

forms, which therefore appears synonymous with what religious language calls “charity,” thus testifying not only to an analogy but also to a real family resemblance between postmetaphysical philosophy and the Christian tradition (from which it originates).

However, the acknowledgement of a family resemblance in the end clashes with questions of ultimacy, that is, eschatology. The history of salvation of which we have spoken with regard to Joachim is the history of *salvation*. Let me make a few remarks on the mysterious meaning of this chapter’s title, “God the Ornament.” It is an expression that came to my mind while reading the Book of Revelation (as is well known, this text is central to Joachim, since he dedicated to it one of his most important works) years ago. What struck me in those pages was the overabundance of forms, lights, and colors, as if the revelation (according to the etymology of *apokalypsis*) of salvation at the end of time was not so much a destructive catastrophe as a transfer of things on the plane of phantasmagoria, a dissolution of the real into “secondary” qualities bound with the perception of the senses. We should not forget that the word *spirit* (*pneuma*) means etymologically breath, wind, blowing, something volatile, fleeting, of which thought lost the memory when it began conceiving of spirit as the evident and indubitable foundation of self-consciousness, up to Hegel’s “absolute spirit.” I cannot avoid recalling here another idea that comes often to mind when I think about *What Computers Still Cannot Do* (which is the title of a famous book by Hubert Dreyfus). It seems to me, whether rightly or wrongly, that what computers cannot do is precisely perceive secondary qualities, or at least the most secondary among them: a certain perfume, an atmosphere, the threatening air that in certain circumstances warns us that we have to be on the alert, even though there is nothing “concrete” that might be grasped by a computer or a robot.

The weakening of Being toward which, in my hypoth-

esis, the history of our civilization is directed can be described as a history of salvation insofar as it prepares for the transfer of reality on the plane of secondary qualities, of the spiritual, and of the ornamental; we might even add, the virtual. We might then draw closer to the spiritual—not literal—meaning of *kenosis* of the divine *Verbum*. The Logos did not humiliate himself just so that we might understand his teaching, and then go back to the heavens to prepare for us an eternal life that can be reached only in another world. Despite his authentic faithfulness to the Church of his epoch, Joachim does not say much about the transition from the third epoch to salvation occurring in another world. True, even if he does not deny the immortality of the soul, eternal life appears to him only as the epoch of spirit. This epoch does not consist in the mere preparation for something else. World history is not exclusively a time of trial that will end with the destruction of the natural order and the transition to the supranatural realm.

Although philosophy does not have any means of deciding the question of immortality, it is at least clear that, after the end of metaphysics, philosophy cannot support (provide the support Thomas Aquinas found in Aristotle) arguments about nature and supranature. The philosopher, like any other religious man, can only hope that life will not end with the death of the body. It is not an unreasonable hope to the extent that there are no “metaphysically” certain limits of nature (which, for some, preclude the survival of the individual soul). Whether salvation is realized in this world or beyond death, the salvation addressed by the Judeo-Christian revelation, understood spiritually in light of Joachim’s teaching and of the end of metaphysics, appears as the lightening and weakening of the “heavy” structures in which Being has manifested itself throughout human civilization. Hence, we retrieve here the dream of Idealism, which is not exclusively Hegel’s but also Marx’s:

the world becomes truly the dwelling of man (where man can feel at home, *bei sich*) only if man becomes, in multiple senses, spirit: spirit as *pneuma*, breath, the lightest breath that moves the air around us. (I am thinking of Heidegger's passage on the *Gering*, the marginal.²) This spiritualization is not too different from the total disclosure of self-consciousness in Hegel's absolute spirit, or from Marx's unalienated humanity. The idea of spiritualization I have illustrated here emphasizes the aesthetic aspect of these two versions of salvation (Hegel's and Marx's), though not so much, or not only, in the sense of the realization of harmony (which echoes Dewey's idea of fulfillment). The aesthetic here is the term, which reveals a condition in which reality dissolves its strict contours. It is the plane in which reality is no longer distinguishable from fantasy—what we also call the “poetic.” Let me remark that Heidegger, in his commentary on Hölderlin, gives a lot of weight to the verses that say: *Voll verdienst, doch—dichterisch wohnet der Mensch auf dieser Erde* (full of merit, yet poetically, man inhabits this earth).

Our civilization, which we have reached through mechanical and computer technology, political democracy, social pluralism, and the availability of goods necessary to ensure survival, offers us the chance to realize the kingdom of spirit, understood as lightening and poeticization of the real. I am saying that it *offers* the chance. I am fully aware that poeticization is at the present moment absolutely imaginary. Even when Joachim spoke of the beginning of the epoch of spirit, he predicted that the struggle to realize it in this world would be hard. Spiritualization, which is today within the realm of technological possibility and of the evolution of ideas, demands to be pursued with a difficult kind of action. The appearance of easiness and moral disengagement, which this thesis might stimulate, has to do with the fact that the salvation—or emancipation—it prefigures has a densely aesthetic and poetic connotation.

This, however, is the only connotation that can fill the otherwise empty *figure* of the end of human history, no matter how it is conceptualized: whether as the *telos* of emancipation, which bestows meaning upon the life of each of us within the unsurpassable earthly limits of birth and death, or as a condition realizable in the eternal life after death. Even in the latter case—as Joachim and (my) philosophy teach—salvation must begin in the here and now, otherwise the story of its development would no longer make sense. Then, the play would be entrusted to a divinity that transcends any capacity for relation that we might possess—of which, therefore, it would be preferable not to speak at all.

If there is salvation somewhere, it has the features of lightening rather than justice. Might this be one of the meanings of the divine mercy and forgiveness running through the Bible? The passage of the gospel in which Jesus promises the apostles that in eternal life they will sit upon the twelve thrones and judge the twelve tribes of Israel should probably not be taken in legal but rather in aesthetic terms. Eternal life is nothing but the “perfect” enjoyment of meanings and spiritual forms generated by the history of humanity, which now constitute the “kingdom” of immortality. To draw closer to that life here and now would mean to realize the conditions in which a more perfect aesthetic enjoyment of meaning can be increasingly given. The establishment of “righteous” historical orders has only this aim.

It would not be scandalous to put Herbert Marcuse’s name (in addition to Nietzsche’s and Heidegger’s, to which I have already referred) next to that of Joachim of Fiore. The idea of weakening that I have described as the guiding thread of a nonmetaphysical ontology that recognizes its family resemblance with the religious tradition of the West calls attention to the fact that today the human being has at his disposal the technological, conceptual, and political possibilities to begin to realize the kingdom of sense. The

simultaneity in which the world of generalized communication makes available, at least in principle, “all” that human culture has produced or produces, as in a sort of imaginary museum, orients us toward weakening. If we do not welcome the appeal of aesthetic emancipation offered to us by the new condition of existence, it is because we are still oppressed by the letter—the literalism of the sacred texts (the fetish of fundamentalism of all sorts) and the world’s materiality, the unsatisfied needs and injustices in the distribution of goods that are indispensable to life. Although we can only catch a glimpse of this possibility, the epoch of spirit announces itself to us with a specific strength, which is bound up with the postmodern condition. To hear this announcement, if only in theory, is already a way of preparing for its realization.

4



History of Salvation, History of Interpretation

A COMMA DISJOINS the two parts of the title. It is clearly a patch: for lack of a better term, it is an approximate solution. There could have been a colon or a dash; however, it would have not been possible to replace the comma with a *sive*, a “that is.” Somehow—and I do not think that it is just a deconstructive chattering—this is the real topic of the following remarks.

The comma is not a neutral joint, as a simple conjunction might have been, bringing near the two terms so as to announce, more simply, an analysis of their relation. The preference for a comma here—or a colon, or a dash—underscores that it is not a question of analyzing two themes, which are anyway defined in their own terms, in order to establish the relations or differences between them. The theme arises properly out of the recognition that it is possible for us today, if not obligatory, to move from one term to the other. One does so by following a type of relation that cannot be easily recognized as a simple identity—*seu*, *sive*, that is—or as a difference between two autonomous thought-contents, which would disclose their proximity or

distance. What I mean to suggest with this title is the need to thematize the point of departure where we find ourselves—no matter how problematic that “we” may be—that is to say, the pre-understanding in which we are placed, and of which we become aware when we problematize our pre-understanding. Our point of departure is that the relation between these two terms is closer, and yet more vague or opaque, than would have been suggested by a relationship of identity or by a simple parataxis.¹

I do not mean to say that the history of salvation is the history of interpretation, or that there are significant relations between the two terms (notions, events) that would be worthy of inquiry with the right kind of research. Rather, I mean to echo a “crossing,” the rustle of a slippage from one term to the other, a slippage of which we are all aware. Our pre-understanding of this slippage constitutes our common, historical belonging to the world (epoch, history, culture) of the religions of the Book. If we replaced the comma with an *is*, we would have to make an effort to hear it as a transitive verb: the history of salvation lets be the history of interpretation, or the history of salvation occurs, gives itself, as the history of interpretation.

It seems to me that it is justified to insist on what might appear a marginal question of punctuation. In fact, a more appropriate tone for this discourse is not that of a “scientific” investigation (or only apparently scientific, as it can be in disciplines like philosophy), but that of a meditation seeking to grasp a relationship, which seems to impose itself with a certain undeniability and which is nevertheless a fleeting relationship.

Interpretation—primarily of sacred texts—has always dealt with the issue of salvation in the Judeo-Christian tradition. (Note that there is already a meaningful difference between a discourse on interpretation and salvation, and a discourse on the history of the one or the other. I shall not dwell on this, as it may become clearer later on; yet this

difference resonates and echoes in the title as well as in its immediate illustrations.) From its beginning, modern hermeneutics has reflected on salvation, as in Schleiermacher, whose work in its most immediate sense has to do with preaching and with pastoral explication of sacred texts to the faithful (*subtilitas intelligendi, subtilitas explicandi*, in the hermeneutical terminology of the time). Salvation requires understanding the Word of God in Scripture and its correct application to our condition and situation (*subtilitas applicandi*). Furthermore, it is necessary to interpret Scripture without contradicting reason, making use of our faculties to respect thoroughly the Word of God and avoiding the attribution of aberrant meanings to Scripture (even Spinoza, after all, is motivated by this essentially pious purpose; however, during the Enlightenment, it was on this terrain that criticism arose).

In another sense, however, salvation and interpretation are joint in the Christian tradition, linking Jesus to the prophets, as heard in New Testament expressions like: "You heard it was said . . . , but I say. . . ." Here interpretation is no longer only a tool (of the faithful) for understanding what God reveals and expects; the event of salvation (Jesus' coming) is itself, deep down, a hermeneutical occurrence. But it can be called hermeneutical only to a point: it is true that Jesus is the living interpretation of the meaning of the law and the prophets (here another meaning of the Logos that becomes flesh: the incarnation of the Logos, of meaning, of the Jewish Scriptures), but somehow, he is also its fulfillment. Thus Jesus seems to be announced as the definitive deciphering of sense—as if after him there were no longer any space or necessity for interpretation. Yet (it would suffice to reflect on the interpretations of the so-called consequent eschatology) although salvation is essentially "fulfilled" in the incarnation, death, and resurrection of Jesus, it awaits a further fulfillment. Thus the Paraclete, the Spirit of Truth bestowed upon the faithful at Pentecost,

has been assigned the task of assisting them in this further hermeneutical project. We should not forget that the Spirit (the one who gives life to the text, the true sense of the “letter”), namely the more exquisitely hermeneutical person of the Trinity, is also the one through whom the Son becomes human in the bosom of Mary. The Trinity is a hermeneutical structure *par excellence*, for the Son is the Logos of the Father and the Spirit is their relation, the hypostatizing of their love-understanding. If we follow through these elementary subjects of the Christian teaching in a spirit of loyalty to the catechism, the relationship between interpretation and salvation becomes more complex: it introduces overwhelmingly the feature of history into the main picture. It is more and more difficult to attribute the pure sense of a subjective genitive to “the history of interpretation,” according to which interpretation has a history but is basically something that takes place in the immediate relation between reader and sacred text, the latter being posited once and for all with its definitive sense, which the believer must only decipher and apply.

If interpretation continues after the resurrection of Jesus (indeed by virtue of the resurrection, as its continuation and authentication), this means that interpretation and salvation, too, have a history that is not only an accidental occurrence crossing above or near their supposedly stable kernels. Rather, this history affects them deeply, in a sense that can only be explained by emphasizing the “objective” genitive in the two expressions. Salvation takes shape, takes place, gives itself, and constitutes itself through its history, and thus the history of interpretation, too—through a series of connections that can be only with difficulty frozen into a scheme. It is true that the announcement of salvation is given once and for all—in Jesus and the prophets—but it is equally true that, having given itself, it needs interpretations that receive it, actualize it, and enrich it. The history of salvation that continues in the age of the Spirit, after

the descent of the Paraclete at Pentecost, is not simply driven by the biological fact of the presence of ever new human generations that must be evangelized. Rather, it is history, just as the Old Testament narrative up to the Messiah's coming was history. This history has a meaning and a direction, and the interpretation of Scripture that takes place in it is its constitutive dimension. It is not only a tale of errors, or conversely of close or literal understanding of meaning given once and for all in Scripture (which would be as inessential in itself as the errors). The history of salvation continues as the history of interpretation in the strong sense in which Jesus himself was the living, incarnate interpretation of Scripture.

But, even assuming that we have given an accurate—albeit cursory—representation of this event, is it not in the end only the business of theologians, of historians of religions? In other words, the interpretation of which we speak in the title, whose history stands in a deep and complex relationship with the history of salvation, seems to be finally only the interpretation of Scriptures. Would it not be better to add this qualification in the title in order to avoid inappropriate generalizations, or confusion and equivocation?

The fact is that it seems difficult to bring the issue to closure within such restricted and precise (disciplinary) boundaries. Is ours a “religion of the Book,” which we will leave eventually behind through the irresistible process of secularization? Or, more important, do we belong to a culture or civilization of the Book that still affects us deeply, even when we think, or might think, that we no longer have anything in common with the religion of the Book? Does this culture or civilization of the Book not have any relation—at the same time both vague and deep—with the religion of the Book, so much so that it becomes difficult to confine our “history of interpretation” to the history of the interpretation of Scripture?

Of course, one can rightfully argue that the relationship of modern European civilization with sacred Scripture is only a particular instance of the civilization of the Book, which has deeper and more distant origins. In this civilization of the Book, or of writing (in lower case), interpretation is a general phenomenon that is not based and does not depend on the interpretive model of Scripture. This can be granted. Indeed, the Greeks used Hesiod and Homer as the foundational texts in their education, and conceived of their culture as interpretation of these texts—at least to some extent.

Thus the formation of modern Europe has revolved around not only the interpretation of sacred Scripture but also around the interpretation of the Justinian Code and the reading and rereading of the canon of classic literary texts—a textual *corpus* that is not directly related to the sacred Scripture (although this could be debated, too). But the idea of the productive act of interpretation could not have originated in the interpretation of legal codes or in the interpretation of literary and poetic classics, even though it is obvious—as Gadamer illustrates in *Truth and Method*—that the notion of application makes juridical hermeneutics more sensitive to this idea. By contrast, consider the classicist tradition that runs through the whole history of European art and literature, wherein one can read of an ever-returning negation of the productiveness of interpretation on behalf of a literal loyalty to models (a loyalty that is always conceptualized rigidly even when one becomes nostalgically aware of its impossibility, as in Romanticism).

What I want to suggest is that the idea of the productiveness of interpretation could only originate as an “effect” of the Judeo-Christian (or specifically Christian) concept of the history of revelation and salvation. By the productiveness of interpretation, I mean that interpretation is not only an attempt to grasp the original meaning of the text

(for example, the authorial intention) and to reproduce it as literally as possible but also to add something essential to the text (to understand it better than its author, the adage resonating in eighteenth-century hermeneutics). This effect is itself an occurrence of interpretation and salvation—and here we find again one of those vertiginous circles, albeit not vicious ones, that unfold when we speak of hermeneutics: in other words, the fact that the European culture of late modernity “discovered” the productiveness of interpretation or—which is the same—the nonepiphenomenality, instrumentality, or secondariness of the commentary. I take this fact, to the extent that it has taken place, as an effect of the interpretation that this culture has given of the Christian message. It is an inseparable effect, or undoubtedly *the* effect, of the Christian event.

But has such a hermeneutical event—an effect of interpretation as well as a way of construing interpretation—really taken place? As I pointed out at the outset, even the argument that such an event has taken place cannot be submitted as an objective or literal description of a state of affairs, but only as an interpretation of the situation in which we are always already thrown.

I take this hermeneutical event to coincide with the phenomenon that in Heideggerian language is called the end of metaphysics in the world of techno-science. Briefly, let me remark that Heidegger calls modern techno-science the end of metaphysics, because science “consumes” definitively the idea that Being is what is indubitably given as simple presence. The ascertained and indubitable presence of the “thing” becomes explicitly an effect of representation in experimental science and in the universal (at least tentatively, in principle) technological manipulation of the world that it has made possible. In other words, the certainty of the object is a pure effect of the process of verification carried out by the subject. When one reaches this

stage by consistently developing the premises already implicit in classical metaphysics, it becomes impossible to identify Being with simple presence.

Although Heidegger did not go very far beyond this simple negation, that is, beyond the recognition of the unfolding of the radical difference between Being and beings, it is easy to see how and why precisely this ontology provides support (in his own work and in that of those who appeal to him) for the broad direction of thought called hermeneutics, which has become a sort of *koine*, a commonplace of contemporary culture. However, one can assign a nonderivative, noninstrumental, or accidental sense to interpretation only through the denial of the identification of Being-true with what is completely and indubitably present.

But is Heidegger's ontology—and the hermeneutics that depends on it—at all connected with the history of Christian revelation? Is this, after all, only a question of hermeneutics unfolding within European culture initially and primarily in relation to the problem of reading and interpreting the sacred Scripture, as can be easily seen by tracing the history of interpretation theory? This fact conceals a larger issue that can be articulated in the following terms: if an ontology of Heidegger's type, which does not want to contradict its own conclusions, "denies" the identity of Being with the objectively present, it cannot announce itself as the description of an "objective structure," that is, present, given, of Being. Rather, it must argue necessarily on the basis of an "interpretation," as a response to a message, a reading of texts, a sending that comes from tradition. (As is well known, terms like *sending* and *tradition* are central to the philosophy of the so-called second Heidegger). Now, it can be argued, even diverging from the Heideggerian texts on this topic—which are very obscure, if not reticent and inconclusive (at least, so it seems to me)—that the sending to which postmetaphysical philos-

ophy, ontology, or hermeneutics corresponds is the tradition of Western Christian civilization.

The thesis thus enunciated seems both too rigid and too generic. Instead, it should be taken mainly as a project of inquiry, which is still largely unfinished (even in Heidegger himself). Only if the interpretive and non-metaphysically descriptive status of ontological hermeneutics is radically acknowledged—a recognition not explicitly made by Heidegger or by his first and most authoritative hermeneutical interpreters, such as Gadamer—can it be both possible and necessary to clarify the link between postmetaphysical ontology and the Western tradition, that is, the fact that ontological hermeneutics is nothing but the theory of Christian modernity.

The basic continuity of Western civilization with the message of the Judeo-Christian Scriptures is generally acknowledged. Here, however, the issue is radicalizing the implications of this recognition. First of all—and this can only be a parenthetical remark—this must be done by exploring in depth Christianity's constitutive role and positive constitution in the birth of modern Western civilization. This is the direction explored by Weber with his analysis of capitalism and the Protestant ethic, although one must move far beyond this specific feature. The point is that the various processes of secularization occurring throughout modernity need not be seen as a leave-taking from the religious source—as is argued by Hans Blumenberg, for example, and by much historiography inspired by the Enlightenment, and also by Catholicism (the Italian Augusto Del Noce). Rather, these can be seen as processes of secularization, application, enrichment, and specification of that source.

One of these “positive” processes of secularization of the Christian message is precisely what Heidegger calls the advent of the end of metaphysics in modern technoscience, and the unfolding of the ontological difference be-

tween Being and particular beings—the same process leading up to the discovery that interpretation is productive. It is not easy—though possible—to show, precisely by retracing the paths explored by Weber, the extent to which the Christian message contributed to the development of modern science, out of which, finally, comes the end of the metaphysics of presence. However, we can easily recall along Weberian lines the significance of monotheism for the development of the scientific vision of the world as well as the conception of the human task of mastering the earth, which God, according to Scripture, assigned to humanity. What can be more easily illustrated is that the outcome of the process—the dissolution of the metaphysics of presence and the reduction of the object to the power of the subject—has come to signify the paving of the way for a sort of global recognition that the truth, including the truth of the hard, experimental sciences, constitutes itself as announcement and interpretation.

The increasingly acute awareness of the historicity of scientific paradigms enables contemporary epistemology to acknowledge that even the natural sciences are connected to the history of interpretation and the history of salvation: there is no truth outside of a horizon disclosed by an announcement, by a word handed over. The transmitted word cannot be set in opposition to the truth of objects that are given as objectively present (the classic distinction between the natural sciences and the sciences of the spirit, between explanation and understanding), since even this self-giving is always made possible by an opening, which is language, and therefore by the word handed over and transmitted—provenance.

Those outlined so far are only the incipient steps on the way toward listening to the sense of the comma linking the two parts of the title. Ontological hermeneutics, which explicitly thematizes the productiveness of interpretation, and the end of the metaphysics of presence as the outcome

of modern techno-science spring from the action of the Christian message throughout the history of Western civilization. They are interpretations that “secularize” this message in the constructive, positive sense of the term. It should be added here that *secularization* is not a term in contrast with the essence of the message, but rather is constitutive of it. Jesus’ incarnation (the *kenosis*, the self-lowering of God), as an event both salvific and hermeneutical, is already indeed an archetypical occurrence of secularization.

If the relation between the history of salvation and the history of interpretation is understood in this way, will not salvation and interpretation be configured just as processes of drifting, in which there seem to be no limits, no criteria of validity, no risk of defeat, and finally, no space for freedom and responsibility, just as in the relation of productive interpretation with the text? In fact, it is all too obvious that once metaphysics has been liquidated, a good, valid interpretation will no longer be configured absolutely as that which is literally or objectively faithful to the text.

What does a productive interpretation generate? It generates Being, new senses of experience, new ways for the world to announce itself, which are not only other than the ones announced “before.” Rather, they join the latter in a sort of *discursus* whose logic (also in the sense of Logos) consists precisely in the continuity. Such a continuity—briefly stated—does not have any objective status; it is reduced (but is it indeed reduction?) to rhetorical persuasion, *ad homines*. But not every secularization is good and positive, and neither is every interpretation valid; it must be valid for a community of interpreters.

With a more explicitly spiritual language, one could say that the only limit of secularization is love, that is, the possibility of communicating with a community of interpreters. It is not paradoxical to assert that the history of modern hermeneutics, in which the Protestant Reforma-

tion has played such an important role, is also a long journey of rediscovery of the Church. It is not without significance for the Church, at least as I intend it here, that this recognition springs from the end of the metaphysics of presence and from the advent of ontological hermeneutics. But this way of conceiving of and experiencing the Church as a community of reference for the validity and continuity of the history of interpretation is continuously exposed to the resurgence of metaphysical temptations, which tend to fall back on the horizon of presence. For instance, the authoritarianism of the Catholic Church lies in the claim to return to a text given once and for all, bringing to closure the process of interpretation not in the name of the continuity of discourse and reception of the community's voice, but in the name of an overwhelming "foundational truth." The latter is assumed to be present somewhere (for example, in the dogmatic definition, or at worst—as one hears more often in the discussions of bioethical issues—in "nature" and its immutable laws).

Thus the reference to a community as the "criterion" for the validity of interpretation cannot be set apart from the recognition that such a criterion is legitimated only by the dissolution of the metaphysics of presence, and as such cannot be invoked outside of the horizon of such a dissolution. Ontological hermeneutics replaces the metaphysics of presence with a concept of Being that is essentially constituted by the feature of dissolution. Being gives itself not once and for all as a simple presence; rather, it occurs as announcement and grows into the interpretations that listen and correspond (to Being). Being is also oriented toward spiritualization and lightening, or, which is the same, toward *kenosis*. It is quite probable that ontological hermeneutics, which is generated from the dissolution of the metaphysics of presence, is not only a rediscovery of the Church but also, and mainly, the retrieval of Joachim of Fiore's dream.

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The West or Christianity

IT IS NOT too difficult to fill with meaning this title, whose intention stimulates curiosity and eventually provokes, because it evokes too many things often in conflict with each other. It is not so much a matter of filling the title with meaning as of emptying it, at least in part, by reducing it to a set of coherent and intelligible terms. The multiple meanings we immediately assign to this linked pair indicate at the very least that we take it as a natural, granted, and unquestionable fact, though we cannot spell out why this is the case, as always happens with preconceptions that are too obvious. To begin with, I ought to clarify that the reference to the essay by Novalis, *Christendom or Europe* (*Christenheit oder Europa*) (1799),¹ is not merely polemical or ironic. Though at the outset that was the sense of the title, when I went back and read the beautiful and intense pages of Novalis's work, I realized that my own relationship to those ideas was much deeper, much more positive, at least in some important aspects, as I hope to show below.

What, then, is the meaning in the title of the equiva-

lence, if not the synonymous identity, of the West and Christianity? Indeed, the “or” immediately excludes another meaning that could be given to the use of the particle, which in part is identical: what we are talking about is a synonymous relation (*sive*) rather than an alternative (*aut aut*) one. It seems to me that this clarification already gives us much to think about. In fact, a large current of opinion in our lay and Catholic world suggests that the “or” be read as an alternative relation, an *aut aut*. Christianity’s relationship with the West is an *aut aut*, at least as it is sometimes understood by a kind of neofundamentalist Catholic movement, which has discovered that the West and its way of life are profoundly irreconcilable with the substance of the Christian message—after the end of the Communist threat, which obliged people to stand united against atheistic totalitarianism without looking too closely for acceptable “allies.” The West, indeed, is a synonym for consumerism, hedonism, a Babel-like pluralism of cultures, loss of center, and obliviousness to any reference to “natural” law. In espousing this thesis, paradoxically (but not really so), Catholic neofundamentalism agrees with the lay defense of the radical autonomy of modernity with respect to the Christian tradition. One of the most recent and well-known formulations of such a thesis is given by Hans Blumenberg’s *The Legitimacy of the Modern Age*.²

In his polemic with authors like Karl Löwith, who have—rightly, I think—construed modernity as a “secularizing” drift of the Judeo-Christian heritage (above and beyond the Greek heritage),³ Blumenberg holds that modernity defines itself on the basis of values that are entirely new with respect to tradition, and that can be summed up as a new disposition of the human being toward the world (a position similar to that of the Enlightenment and of much of nineteenth-century historicism, included Hegel’s Phenomenology). This disposition is characterized as the will to organize reality in accordance with a rationality that is

entirely independent from any utopia. From this perspective, Copernican man is contrasted with Ptolemaic man: true, Ptolemy placed himself at the center of the universe, but his position was ultimately upheld by the authority of the Creator. Copernican man has rolled away from the center—as Nietzsche writes in a famous fragment—but the center is empty, and there is no authority superior to reason (especially scientific reason), through which man may autonomously make of the world his own home.

There are good reasons to argue that these formulations, which construe the relation of the West (or Europe, or modernity) with Christianity as a polemical alternative, are insufficient and ultimately untenable. The first formulation that comes to mind, which, while superficial, points in the right direction, can be summed up as follows: the radical alternative, as it is conceived of by fundamentalist Catholicism, has a reactionary, or at least a nostalgic and definitively “not realistic,” outlet (let us say at the outset that this is not a limitation because values should coincide with factual reality, but rather because it entails more than the risk of remaining an unachievable project)—the exit from modernity by recovering a more authentic, prior condition of morality and religiousness, and so on. Note that the impossibility of the fundamentalist project of “restoration” often paves the way for the most appalling compromises in practice, as we recently witnessed in Italian politics. The thesis concerning the new and autonomous legitimacy of modernity implies, for its part, an excessive dose of confidence in the possibility of the radically new and an overall emphasis on the creativity, originality, and absolute freedom of man: all modern dogmas, or perhaps myths, which belong to the epoch whose origin they are meant to explain, appear less obvious at the moment when many perceive modernity as a completed stage, or at least one whose constitutive values are problematic.

If one tries to go beyond these “superficial” reasons for

the critique of the alternative theses on modernity while still moving in the direction toward which they point, one sees that both versions of the *aut aut* between Christianity and modernity are unsatisfactory or simply untenable, because they believe themselves capable of calling themselves out of history, of their own provenance. This is true not only, as seems obvious, for Blumenberg's thesis, which conceives of modernity as a "beginning" in some absolute sense. It holds also for the fundamentalist Catholic version of the thesis, which reasons also as if modernity did not have precedents and roots in the Judeo-Christian tradition. According to this perspective, the Judeo-Christian tradition is a complete denial of modernity. In turn, this view believes itself capable of judging modernity from the outside while remaining immune to the effects of the latter's decline. In sum: both theses make a "panoramic" claim. While one does not grasp the links between modernity and Christianity, the other does not grasp the fact of its own belonging to both.⁴

We could further develop this discussion. I shall only note here that at the core of hermeneutics is precisely the awareness of this provenance, and belonging, and the critique of any "panoramic" claim with respect to history. This core of hermeneutics is still far from having shown all its fecundity and its implications for theoretical and moral philosophy, and for the very concept of religion.

It is hermeneutics, in the end, that with all its philosophical implications shows the basic insufficiency of the two theses of the *aut aut*, and that directs us instead toward a preference of the secularization thesis—*secularization* understood not as abandonment and alternative but rather as continuation and, ultimately, destiny. Indeed, the thesis of secularization retains all the elements present in the other theses (here too one can see, perhaps, a sign of its validity: it "encompasses" opposing theses), but situates them in a historical and existential framework that is not abstractly

rationalist and therefore not panoramic. It is true that modernity can be represented also as a defense of the autonomy of man with respect to the sacred, as the gaze's turn toward earthly reality. From this perspective, it can be represented as a position that separates itself from an earlier religious consciousness. However, these phenomena are not intelligible as radical abandonment nor as absolute novelty, because understanding them in this way would amount to ignoring what in other contexts is called the hermeneutic circle, which we can refer to as belonging and provenance.

What is the meaning, then, and what are the theoretical and eventually "practical" consequences (in the sense of a judgment about historical behavior, political options, moral choices, and so on) of the thesis that the West is secularized Christianity? Let me point out that if what I have said about the validity that must be recognized in the two alternative theses of the *aut aut* is true, then this affirmation means also that the West is secularized Christianity and nothing else. In other words, if we want to talk about the West, Europe, modernity—which, in my argument, are held to be synonymous—as recognizable and clearly defined historical-cultural entities, the only notion we can use is precisely that of the secularization of the Judeo-Christian heritage. At a time when the West can no longer define itself only as an alternative to the evil empire of communist totalitarianism and when it is making an effort to recover autonomously and positively its own physiognomy, it encounters precisely its own Christian origin, in the form of a heritage that is certainly changed and "shifting" but nevertheless constitutes its sole identifying element.

Thus, the thesis concerning the "equivalence" between Christianity and the West means above all that secularization is not a radical abandonment or break, since this would imply the possibility of an absolutely new beginning, of the kind conceptualized by Blumenberg (from the fun-

damentalist perspective, this would be a “demonic” event). This view, I argue, ignores the hermeneutic circularity into which every existence is *de facto* thrown. However, from this immediately follows that to speak of secularization cannot mean invoking in fundamentalist fashion a return to the authentic origins, to the sacral condition that was erroneously abandoned (we shall see that this is not Novalis’s project, as one might believe), and it does not mean acknowledging the specific, autonomous, and original vocation of modernity with respect to the Judeo-Christian tradition.

Rather, the point is to grasp more radically that the equivalence of the West and Christianity means two things: a) the West, feeling the exigency of affirming its own cultural identity—due above all to the political events mentioned above, the fall of the communist enemy, and at the same time to the economic and political push to build a unified Europe—does not find unifying and identifying elements other than, in a secularized form, a shared Christian origin, which is reflected in the thesis concerning the *aut aut* (which therefore is right about the content it intends to uphold, though it is wrong in the overall meaning conferred upon modernity, i.e. a radical alternative to Christianity); and b) the renewed vitality of Christianity, which manifests itself in the actual religious revival of our epoch, can be nothing else but the recovery of Christianity as the West.

I shall now try to show the validity of these theses, warning that often the arguments in both cases will be the same, though weighed and appraised from different perspectives, one more political-cultural and the other more religious, or if I may say so, theological.

Novalis, in the essay alluded to in this chapter’s title, clearly demonstrated that the unity of Europe is constituted essentially by the Christian tradition. The belief that in Novalis’s view Christian Europe consists of national

states is a misunderstanding that has to do with our conception of Romanticism. Rather, for Novalis, Europe and its divisions are the children of the epoch of Reformation, since then “in a most irreligious manner religion was confined within national borders.”⁵

Novalis’s intuition is confirmed today at a time when at the political level there is an effort to overcome precisely the Europe of national borders. Evidence of this position’s validity is the decisive role the current pope had in the liberation of Eastern Europe from communist domination, which is certainly one of the conditions for the “recovery of the West.” At a time when people think again of a unified Europe, Christianity—and Catholic Christianity in particular, which has historically constituted its unifying element—has gained a renewed currency. The decisive presence of the pope in the recovery and in the liberation of Europe in these years is just a symptom of a broader and more general phenomenon. While trying to recover their identity, Europe and the West encounter their own secularized, Christian origins as the only foundational element.

Indeed, what are Europe, the West, or modernity, if not above all the civilization of scientific, economic, and technological rationality? This rationality, however, as Weber taught us and is repeated *ad infinitum*, has not been realized in any other culture of the planet, even when all the same material conditions have been present, because the Judeo-Christian tradition was “at work” only in the West.⁶ Monotheism (to speak in very rough approximations) is the condition in which nature can be conceived of from the unitary perspective of a physical science, which is the indispensable basis of the technological domination over nature. Christian ethics, above all Protestant ethics, is the condition in which labor, saving, and economic success can be thought of as religious imperatives, and therefore are capable of generating a deep and total engagement. Moreover, a theory has been advanced recently beyond

Weber's thesis, though not necessarily against him, that modern consumerism—which hardly fits within the “austere” Weberian view of capitalism as the effect of Calvinist ethics—is the outcome of the secularization of the Christian kernel. In Colin Campbell's book, *Romantic Ethics and the Spirit of Modern Consumerism*,⁷ the relationship between consumerism and Christianity is stated clearly, though not as explicitly as here. Campbell shows that the inclination for consumption cannot be sufficiently explained with the argument of the manipulation of tastes and expectations through advertising, which allegedly reflects the expansive demands placed on the market by an industry that has intensified to the extreme its productive capacities. Instead, in order to explain consumerism, it is necessary to explore the deeper transformation of the European mentality, which may be characterized as the development of a curiosity about alternative worlds and the tendency toward fantasy, and therefore an intense desire of novelty. These traits of the European mentality, which, according to Campbell, were explicitly affirmed in Romanticism, are themselves, similarly to the ethics of Weber's capitalist, effects of the secularization of Christian religiosity. The beginning of modernity and the shake-up of the Reformation weakened the “literal” faith in Christian truths, leaving in their place an inclination toward other worlds, which might not be otherworldly but in any case are not identical with visible everyday reality. Hence, through a series of phases, the birth of “Romantic” mentality in the common, even banal sense of the term, to which modern and late-modern capitalist consumption must be traced.

It is pointless here to try to decide whether and to what extent Campbell's thesis—which in any case is documented and argued rigorously—must be accepted or not. Instead, this thesis—formulated in the late-modern condition in which we live, and which Weber had not experienced—indicates more than Weber's the direction in which we

must move to develop the idea of the coincidence of the West with (secularized) Christianity. What I intend to argue is that the West is essentially Christian to the extent that the meaning of its own history appears as the “twilight of Being,” that is, the diminishment of reality’s solidity through all the procedures of dissolution of objectivity brought about by modernity.

Indeed, today if we attempt to give substance to the idea of the West, we do not find, only or mainly, capitalist and technological rationality “next to” a series of ideal themes that are linked though ultimately independent and often in conflict, as, for example, Enlightenment rationalism and Christian dogma, which in turn is divided into Protestant, Catholic, and so on. More than at any other time, all these ingredients (along with others that we could list) appear to be mixed into a whole that is neither organic nor rigorous, but from which elements of strict differentiation are missing. For example, the popularity of the pope in today’s world corresponds not only to his lively presence in the political arena or to the recovery of religious faith, of Catholic Orthodoxy and so on. It is probably linked more to the general disappearance of strict differentiations, which has been brought about especially by the spread of mass media. What is often deplored as confusion—always from excessively strict and dogmatic perspectives, whether lay or religious—and as the commodification of all values produced by the media is instead the condition for establishing a tolerance that, as it is easy to see, can only point to the weakening of the idea of truth, and ultimately of reality. (Let me use this terminology without further illustrations: it is the theme of a theory I have proposed under the name of “weak thought”⁸). It is above all for these reasons that today the West can be characterized in many interrelated senses as the land of the twilight, or also of secularization, which is the same thing. Here I outline only some of the traits that in my view allow me to speak in

these terms: secularization appears, above all in its Weberian sense, as the application of ethics and of the monotheistic, Judeo-Christian world view to the constitution of capitalism, natural science, and modern technology. Furthermore, the secularization of Christianity is also that opening to other worlds that, as I have mentioned with respect to Campbell, is the foundation of consumerism. Secularization is then the weakening of the sense of reality brought about by science, which studies entities that are increasingly incomparable with those we encounter in our everyday experience. Such a weakening is produced, too, at another level: the world of the “natural” need no longer function as foundation-reality, since we no longer know what it actually is, subjected as we are by the world of production (merchandise), advertising, and so on to the manipulation, or better, to the transformation of our imagination. The same holds true for history and information: historians are more and more aware that knowledge of the past is made possible but also irretrievably conditioned by the application of rhetorical narrative conventions that prevent its objective representation. These conventions serve the same culture that produces them; thus, since the end of Eurocentrism, of Western imperialism, etc., we no longer can speak of a universal history as the ground of specific histories. In the end, then, there is no such thing as history. The same can be said for common knowledge: there is a pluralism of sources of information that no longer “mirror” but rather interpret. It is obvious that these sources never really “mirrored” events, but today the novelty is the fact that everybody is aware of their interpretive nature (everybody knows that the TV lies).

Does it make sense to place all these phenomena under the sign of secularization? It seems that for Weber and the idea of capitalism as the secularizing development of monotheism, there are no doubts about it. Rather, what might be a problem is so labeling the postmodern development

of the drift, described by Weber, toward a weakening of the sense of reality and of the notion of truth itself, which I mentioned above. I shall not attempt to put forth an exhaustive argument for this “extension” of the term *secularization*—I intend to attempt this elsewhere. I just want to clarify the meaning of the hypothesis advanced here, which seems worthy of discussion and corroboration. The hypothesis, briefly, is the following: if the West seeks its own identity, it must principally reckon with the phenomena indicated above, namely a Weberian capitalist rationalization plus the world of information and of proliferating interpretations without a center, which tends to weaken the sense of the terms *being* and *reality*. Now this set of phenomena may well be grasped as a whole only if it is seen as a major process of the secularization of the Judeo-Christian tradition. Just as Weber, in trying to find the “distinctive” element for understanding why modern capitalism was born in the West, encountered monotheism and the Protestant ethic, so too today the phenomena alluded to above in a cursory fashion seem comprehensible only in light of the Christian tradition. Let me repeat that here I shall not provide a proper demonstration for this statement; however, one may understand its reasonableness and plausibility by calling to mind arguments such as that made by Campbell on consumerism, and above all by not understanding the reference to Weber as merely an analogy. I mean that, as far as they are connected to the spread of information technologies, the phenomena of weakening mentioned above are linked to secularization in the sense in which Weber intended, precisely via techno-science, which began as the mechanical science of motors and assembly lines and became the science of electronics—TV, computers. Another, more important way of legitimating the use of the term *secularization* for these phenomena of weakening is that which seeks not merely to bring them back to their origin (that is, to that without which they

cannot be explained, for then one would proceed along the way paved by Weber, and underline that the society of communication and limitless interpretation is shaped by the logical continuation of a world that has Scripture as its foundation and that develops above all as exegesis). Rather, this approach emphasizes that the weakening of Being is one possible meaning—if not the absolute meaning—of the Christian message, through the radical reading of incarnation as *kenosis*. This message speaks of a God who incarnates himself, lowers himself, and confuses all the powers of this world.⁹

For this part of my argument too, I believe, one might recall the essay by Novalis mentioned above, where he says that “true anarchy is the fertile element of religion.”¹⁰ The context clearly shows that the term *anarchy* here indicates the Babel-like confusion and the loss of center in favor of the multiple, irreducible “pictures” of the world that I have suggested one might call a “weakening of the sense of reality.”

However, as I mentioned at the outset, we must draw on Novalis especially for the conclusion to his text, to suggest, at least schematically, the argument for the plausibility of the second thesis mentioned earlier. According to this thesis, not only is the West today only definable as a unified entity as secularized Christianity, but also, Christianity today rediscovers itself authentically only if it identifies itself as Western. In other and more provocative words: I mean that today the West, understood as the land of the sunset and of weakening, is Christianity’s truth. Two passages by Novalis are worth mentioning here: first, where Novalis defends the “Catholic esoterization of the Bible,” the “sacred violence of the Councils and of the supreme spiritual leader,” against Luther’s *sola scriptura*, because in this way Catholicism ensured that “the absolutely popular character of the Bible, its miserable content, and the roughly abstract outline of religion” that it contained would not become an obstacle to

faith. In other words, the Bible is merely the kernel, which by itself, in contrast with the living tradition and faith of the community, cannot be held to be authentic revelation.

The second passage is at the end of the essay. For Novalis, the living faith of the community that gives us hope for the renewal of Christianity has the quality of “indifferentiation” that I used earlier to characterize the contemporary situation. Novalis writes: “Christianity has three forms. One is the generative element of religion, namely joy in all religion. One is the notion of mediation itself, namely faith in the omnipotence of all earthly things to be bread and wine of eternal life. One is the faith in Christ, his mother and the saints. Choose whichever you will, choose all three, it is all the same, you will become Christians thereby and members of one single, eternal, inexpressibly happy community.”¹¹ There is no point in analyzing further the meaning of these three forms as Novalis himself thought of them. He certainly opposed the idea of retrieving the authenticity of revelation by returning to the Bible—to the idea of a “broad” Christianity, somewhat vague, not dogmatically defined—which tends to coincide with the religious spirit theorized by Schleiermacher in the *Speeches on Religion*, which Novalis explicitly cites in his essay. Catholicism always taught that the sources of revelation are both Scripture and tradition, and therefore always acknowledged, at least in principle, that revelation continues and is enriched in the living faith of community (though only up to a point); *de facto*, it always has greatly restricted community boundaries by identifying the Church as a hierarchical organization led by the pope and bishops and defined by the respect for Scripture. Today, in the name of this vision of community, the Catholic Church is far from acknowledging the elements of “lay” religiousness that announce themselves in Western culture. On the contrary, it meets them with skepticism, manifested in an unnecessary emphasis on a strictly disciplinary conception

of Christian practice (I am thinking, obviously, of sexual morality, which claims to be based on “natural law”). But if, as I believe, we acknowledge (for example, along with Novalis) that the truth of revelation is contained *in nuce* in the Scriptures, and that it grows and increases in the experience of community, we probably will have to follow the same path as Novalis: the Christian community cannot be too arbitrarily limited by references to the letter of Scripture. The experience of modernity—which I have suggested must be interpreted as the weakening of reality’s peremptoriness, and in a related sense, of authoritarianism in politics, of the strict hierarchical conception of the individual subject, and of direct violence that is consumed and attenuated in the mechanisms of the modern right-based state—must be considered in effect a Christian event. Better still, it is the Christian event *par excellence*, as attestation that the seed of divine Word has borne fruit in a broad field and has not allowed itself to be enclosed and hardened within the authoritarian boundaries of dogma.

To conclude in a provisional way, it is certain that we cannot say that “everything goes.” If it does not have the strict boundaries of dogma and of hierarchical authority, a “vague” Christianity that we have seen theorized by Novalis has charity and love as its distinctive characteristics. The importance that notions like communication, community, dialogue, consensus, democracy, etc. have assumed in a broad area of contemporary philosophy appears not to be accidental but rather to indicate a “conclusion” of modern thought, which tends in multiple philosophical formulations very different among themselves to conceive of truth more as consensus—we might say as charity, too—than as “objectivity.” To grasp and develop the meaning of these signs is the task that today presents itself to those who profess to be openly Christian, and to the many who, outside of any respect for hierarchy, have understood that “they cannot not call themselves Christians.”¹²

*The Death or Transfiguration of Religion*

TWO SETS OF facts seem obvious in contemporary culture, and they do not have the same meaning. Indeed, as I hope to demonstrate, the task of critical thought is elaborating the difference between them. Let me begin with the most visible phenomena surrounding the renewal of religion, which are also the most vaguely defined. This is what we might call, following the title of a book published in France a few years ago, the triumph of God. The current Catholic pope has an extraordinary audience among non-Catholics and nonbelievers, in part because of his contribution to the collapse of the regimes of “real socialism.” The revival of the Catholic Church’s presence in social and cultural domains—I ignore to what extent it is manifested in an increased participation in Mass and the sacraments, but it is certainly visible as a general social phenomenon—has been accompanied by the intensification of more or less heterodox religious experiences. These have their inspiration in Christian roots as well as in the Muslim tradition, but also in Eastern religious traditions, Buddhism first among them. My aim here is not to carry out an accurate

sociological analysis, for which I possess neither the competence nor the analytical tools. Instead, I want to call attention to these “facts,” which need no demonstration since we are all aware of them, to counter the description of ours as a “post-Christian” or “postreligious” epoch given by thinkers such as Richard Rorty.

The reasons for the renewed vitality of religion are many, but some are especially clear. One is, insofar as the Catholic Church is concerned, the contribution of the pope to the collapse of communism in the eastern bloc countries. Another is that, at least in Italy, there is less direct involvement in politics by the Catholic religious hierarchy—though I wonder if something similar is not happening, too, in Spain after Franco. As a result, religious commitment now appears in a more authentic light, no longer confused with the alternatives of reactionary and progressive, or Marxist atheist and Christian democrat. In a broader perspective, the gravity of the problems facing our societies in the wake of recent developments in science and technology gives weight to the voice and presence of religion—in the West, Christianity and specifically Catholicism. I am thinking, of course, of problems linked to bioethics and ecology. In particular, the field of bioethics, where the emerging questions appear far too big to be resolved solely by rational argument and involve life and death (a kind of Columns of Hercules), freedom and self-determination—that is, the destiny of humanity. It is a terrain where one inevitably draws near the sacred. Nietzsche prophesied that modern science (grounded as it is on specialized and collective labor, with every scientist working on very specific and limited topics) would usher in a new model of thought, both moderate and generous. Rather than seeking ultimate truths on which the salvation of the soul would depend, such thought would live in the proximal. “Who cares about me?” This is, for Nietzsche, the motto of the future thinker. Now the limits reached in many fields by experi-

mental science seem a denial of Nietzsche's prophecy: scientists are more often than not those who face ultimate questions. A strict doctrine, elaborated across the centuries by orthodox discipline—like that of the Catholic Church—can be very appealing to people who are busy applying the results of inquiry to concrete cases. The dogmatic thought of the Church seems to provide criteria that are both rigorous and certain, and not defined with the same degree of veracity and clarity in lay philosophy, permeated as it is by the critical spirit.

A number of reasons could be given for the renewed attention paid to religion in our present world, and especially to the voice of the churches. One kind of justification should not be forgotten here: the meaning of religion for social groups looking for an identity by which to save themselves from a situation of *anomie* (the term coined by Durkheim) in which the late-industrial world has thrown them. This need for identity, together with the magnitude of the new moral problems mentioned above, is a powerful factor behind the revival of religion in our societies. This need, like the moral problems, tends to confer on this revival the sense of a return to a foundation, that is, a renewed acceptance of strict discipline and doctrines. Consequently, there is a clear risk of lapsing into fanaticism and intolerance.

And here let us recall the second set of phenomena to which I alluded at the outset. The death of religion of which this chapter's title speaks appears to have been taking place for a long time within and for philosophy, in the sense that perhaps only for philosophers is Nietzsche's sentence about the death of God true. For a long time the main trend of contemporary philosophy—which has developed into two parallel lines of thought that today we tend to call Continental philosophy and analytical philosophy—had no place for theology. It was not a militant atheistic philosophy; that is, it did not theorize explicitly the falseness of religion but rather kept silent about it. It acknowledged

that there are religious experiences radically other than rational thought, a matter of pure feeling, or as in Wittgenstein's famous statement, belonging to the realm of things that, since they cannot be spoken about, should be passed over in silence. Even recent philosophies—I am thinking of that of Lévinas, but also of Ricoeur—that seem to escape this characterization in the end fall within the picture I have drawn at least in the sense that they articulate a purely negative “theology.” They do grant a space to religious experience, or (in Lévinas's case) they even speak of God, but only as an alterity and an emptiness that it is impossible not to acknowledge. However, God (through the Bible) does not address philosophy in a positive manner, and philosophy in turn does not speak about God. Consequently, in Lévinas at least, the name of God merely evokes the finitude of human existence. Yet today the silence of philosophy with respect to God has no basis in any philosophically relevant principle. For the most part, philosophers profess by force of habit to be atheists or nonreligious, almost out of inertia. The fact is that the decline of the great metanarratives—i.e., of the systematic philosophies that had claimed to grasp the true structure of reality, the laws of history, and the method for acquiring knowledge about the only “truth”—has put an end, too, to the strong reasons for philosophical atheism. If the metanarrative of positivism no longer holds, one can no longer think that God does not exist because his existence cannot be established scientifically. If the metanarrative of Hegelian or Marxist historicism no longer holds, one cannot argue that God does not exist because faith in God belongs to an earlier stage within the history of human evolution, or because God is just an ideological representation at the service of domination. True, Nietzsche, whose contribution was decisive in dissolving the metanarratives, is also the philosopher who announced the death of God. Yet this is the main paradox of Nietzsche's philosophy: his an-

nouncement of the death of God, really the announcement of the end of all metanarratives, does not preclude the possibility that many gods might be born. Perhaps we have not meditated sufficiently on the explicit assertion by Nietzsche that “it is the moral God who is denied,” that is, God as ground, the pure act in Aristotle, the supreme watchmaker and architect of the universe in Enlightenment rationalism.

Here, then, is my preliminary understanding of the two “facts” characteristic of our epoch upon which I intend to reflect—though it is vague and imprecise, like all preliminary understandings within which our interpretative appropriation of the world unfolds. On the one hand is the return of religion in our common culture, in the form of a renewed attention to the teaching of the Church, of a need for ultimate truth, and of a desire to recover one’s own identity, especially with reference to transcendence. On the other hand is the collapse of the philosophical principles of atheism, to which philosophy has not yet paid attention but with which it should begin to come to terms, especially considering the first phenomenon mentioned above. The rebirth of religion in the common culture must pose a problem for a philosophy that is accustomed to considering the question of God irrelevant. After all, this same philosophy has seen disappear with the end of metanarratives the very reasons for its traditional atheism or agnosticism. Yet it is almost fate that in this situation a philosophy attentive to the reasons of the present—that is, ultimately preoccupied with “saving the phenomena,” with giving experience its due—will have to recognize the rebirth of religion in our common culture and the good reasons for this rebirth.

With the end of metanarratives and hence the end of metaphysics, can a philosophy that is aware of the absence of strong reasons for atheism ally itself with the new popular religious consciousness—imbued as it is with fundamentalism, communitarianism, anxiety over ethnic iden-

tity, and paternalistic reassurances at the cost of sacrificing freedom? My argument is that, if philosophy recognizes that it can no longer be atheistic because of the collapse of the metanarratives of metaphysics, it can find in this awareness the basis for a critical position on the turn to religion and its dangerous fundamentalist features. As long as contemporary philosophy continues to consider itself atheistic or agnostic, thus repeating its prior metaphysical position out of inertia, it separates itself from common consciousness, placing itself in an “esoteric” site. This is precisely the move effectively criticized by Hegel in the preface to *Phenomenology of Spirit*, which coincides with its failure as a philosophy. Today, much specialized philosophy is practiced in enclosed university departments that focus almost exclusively on epistemological, historical, and logical topics, and is exposed to the risk of becoming irrelevant, again to use a Hegelian notion. Philosophy can no longer see the social vitality of religion as a phenomenon of cultural backwardness promoted by cunning priests, or as the expression of ideological alienation to be overcome through revolution and through the abolition of the division of labor. Rather, it must grasp within the historical process the principles for critically appraising its outcome, recognizing that philosophy itself belongs to the same process that promotes the return to religion.

To sum up: since philosophy no longer has reasons for justifying atheism, it must grant some legitimacy to religious experience, though only insofar as it recognizes the end of metaphysics. The idea of demythification has been demythified as well, because critical reason has discovered (following Nietzsche) the mythical and ideological nature of claiming a truth that would be free from ideology and myth. However, this does not mean that reason might return to myth, thereby legitimating any ideological lie. The varieties of religious and ethnic fundamentalism pervading our world often find philosophical legitimacy in the appeal

to the end of global metanarratives. Relativist fundamentalism, which has communitarianism as its political form, is widespread today. According to this position, there are only forms of belonging after the end of metanarratives, and the judgment of truth is based only on its correspondence with the paradigms upheld by one's own specific community. The renewal of religion is often accompanied by these attitudes, which are its very strength and supporting horizon.

The question of relativism, which many justifiably find totally marginal as a theoretical problem, acquires meaning only in relation to its implications for fundamentalism and communitarianism. Philosophy cannot avoid posing the following question: Is the newly acquired legitimacy of returning to myth and to communitarian forms of belonging the only logical outcome of the end of metaphysics? Should we give way to a local concept of truth, in which there can be no dialogue but only precarious tolerance or at worst some forms of apartheid, since there is no universal truth?

The thread of the dissolution of metaphysics—which, I believe, makes philosophy more open to the possibility of religion by dismissing the strong reasons for atheism—can supply criteria for avoiding these irrational outcomes. Metaphysics (in the sense Heidegger gives to this term, as the thought of Being understood as objectivity and ground) does not end because one discovers a better truth, which would refute the current one. This would be just another kind of fundamentalism held to be truer than what preceded it. Metaphysics and metanarratives end because they are no longer necessary or credible, like the moral God who, in Nietzsche, dies because the faithful themselves recognize that he is a superfluous lie. The same dissolution of metaphysics has brought about both modernity and late modernity: technology facilitates existence, thereby reducing our anxiety about questions concerning the ultimate. Experimental science, on which technological progress is

based, spawns a moderate thought that is more attentive to proximity than to first principles. Increasingly, the outcomes of science are irreducible to the unity of a ground, making metaphysics implausible. The structures of society have become more flexible, replacing the natural community with a more heterogeneous and divided society where the single individual is less identifiable. Political power is evolving toward democratic forms, taking a less direct and centralized physiognomy. Since Freud, individual subjectivity appears as a composite ensemble in which every ultimate is provisional, and thus precludes the possibility of being interpreted in relation to a stable ground.

These processes, which comprise the content of modernity and are the true basis for the dissolution of metaphysics, can be described as processes of weakening. Only within this framework is it possible to realize that there are no strong reasons for atheism and to open thought to the possibility of religious experience. However, what is recovered has nothing to do with the hard discipline and strict antimodernism of dogmatic religion, which is expressed in varied forms of fundamentalism and above all in the Catholicism of Pope Jean Paul II. The recovery of religion is not a return to metaphysics but an outcome of metaphysics' dissolution. To come back to Pope Wojtyla's Catholicism, it is not the naturalist or essentialist ethics he has preached on matters of sexual and family morality, going to the extreme of forbidding the use of condoms in the epoch of the spread of AIDS, that can be recovered. To be faithful to the end of metaphysics, which makes its renewal possible, the religion that presents itself anew in our culture must abandon the project of grounding religious ethics upon knowledge of natural essences that are taken as norms, observing instead the freedom of dialogic mediation. This is realized not in the vacuum of individual wills but by claiming reasons that are less absolute and more historically defined. It is a process forged through the mobilization of a

shared culture and of its critique on the basis of criteria inherent within it. The main thread of weakening—of the peremptoriness of ultimate truths; of certainty in the evidence of consciousness; of the sacrality of power, including that of the pope; and so on—can operate as an internal criterion that reveals itself in modernity as the logic for the dissolution of metaphysics, to which critical thought is committed to conform itself.

To what extent, though, does the adoption of this guiding principle for ethical choices and for a general interpretation of modernity also represent a return to religion? I can only mention this issue in passing here, but it is not unlikely that by taking up this main thread Western thought will recover its profound continuity with the Christian tradition, albeit one freed of its metaphysical masks, or—what amounts to the same—institutional (Church) and disciplinary masks. Will a concept of the course of history as driven toward emancipation by diminishing strong structures (in thought, individual consciousness, political power, social relations, and religion) not be a transcription of the Christian message of the incarnation of God, which Saint Paul also calls *kenosis*—that is, the abasement, humiliation, and weakening of God? This is not a new idea: it was articulated by Hegel more or less in these terms; it is also found in the nineteenth century, in Wilhelm Dilthey's reconstruction of the history of the dissolution of Western metaphysics, in which, according to him, Christianity had a determinant role.¹

Despite its limits, this vision might well define the horizon for resuming the dialogue between philosophy and religion in the Western world, thereby also inspiring the philosophical critique of fundamentalist superstitions that too often threaten to destroy this dialogue in our society.

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*Christianity and Cultural Conflicts in Europe*

THERE ARE MANY indications that the relationship of Christianity to the potential hardening or exacerbation of cultural conflicts is not a peaceful one. I mean that today it would be difficult for anyone at first to take this title, “Christianity and Cultural Conflicts in Europe,” as a reference to Christianity as a means of resolving or mitigating cultural conflicts. At first blush, Christianity would appear to be, if not a specific source of conflict, at least one of the terms involved. In other words: the presence in the Western world of a Christian tradition as a continuous background, albeit a vaguely defined one without a univocal meaning, is not an element for leveling out conflicts; on the contrary, it is (or has become) a constitutive factor in promoting them, and can exacerbate them. What happens here is similar to what happens in the interpretation of the relationship between religion and politics, as can be observed in several recent debates, where this relationship is almost naturally felt to be a risk for the autonomy of politics. Rarely or never has religion been seen as a potentially positive contributing factor to the enrichment and im-

provement of politics. It seems clear that here we are facing the outcome of specific historical experiences. For instance, in Italy the reason for a defensive approach to the relationship between religion and politics lies in the long history of interference on the part of the Catholic Church in the electoral process. But, in much more general terms, the notion that the Christian tradition might take part in or promote cultural conflicts arises at the end of Eurocentrism: European civilization is no longer seen as representing the natural, normal development of all human cultures, which it has the legitimacy to bring together under its aegis. Thus Christianity no longer appears as the revelation of truth, which sheds light on the darkness of “other” cultures and frees them of errors and limitations. Rather, it is a religion—and a culture—that confronts other traditions as one of the terms involved in cultural conflicts, rather than as the solution to those conflicts.

After all, not even within the Western world does Christianity appear to operate as a unifying factor. Here, too, are the more remote—and less obvious—origins of the suspiciousness of politics toward religion: even in the West, Christianity has promoted conflict more often than unity and peace. In eliminating religious themes from the lay realm, Western societies have tried to solve the problem of Christianity’s transformation from element of cohesion to element of conflict. This transformation coincides with the beginning of European modernity itself, the Protestant Reformation, and the wars of religion, and extends into our epoch. Liberalism has meant the reduction of religion to the private sphere, or at most to the realm of civil society. Once excluded from the areas of struggle for political power and distribution of economic resources, religious choice and belonging cease to represent a threat to social peace. But is the liberal solution to this issue still viable when new religious subjects, that is, “other” cultures that in the meantime have settled among us, are involved? Can

we take it as a model for dealing with intercultural conflicts?

The answer is probably negative. Rather, the situation seems to be the following: the lay space of politics, which seems to be well established in Western liberal societies, does not succeed with equal certainty in peacefully including other cultures present in our societies, or at least some of them. These tend to see the very secularity of the political as a threat to their authenticity, and therefore take it less as a condition of liberty than as a negative limitation that must be overcome. An emblematic example is the story surrounding the prohibition of the *chador* in French public schools. The ban on wearing very visible uniforms and distinctive signs, which as affirmative markers of cultural identity might generate conflicts, was motivated by the aim of establishing a secular condition wherein religious freedoms, or even nonreligious ones, were guaranteed. However, the cultural identity that would be affirmed explicitly here is other—that of a relatively alien minority with respect to a more established local tradition. If we compare the prohibition of the *chador* with the widely accepted presence in European schools of Christian symbols (the crucifix hanging on the school wall in many countries is no longer even contested, except in a few cases), we grasp the salient traits of our situation. European society is on average lay and secularized, but in terms of a fairly explicit Christian heritage. This becomes clear when confronting persons or groups rooted in different traditions, who perceive our secularity as deeply marked by a specific religious origin. Liberalism believed that religion could be set aside by relegating it to the private sphere of feeling and faith, which does not “interfere” with political choices and the normal dialectic of power. Yet this separation succeeded only because it was realized on the solid, if unacknowledged, basis of a common religious heritage.

The lay space where religion has ceased to be a factor

of conflict was carved out in Western modernity within a broader, though less acknowledged, religious space of Christian, Judeo-Christian, or biblical origin. All this can be stated in different ways: for example, through the glib saying (which I continue to find very significant), “Thank God I am an atheist”; or, in less paradoxical terms, through the recognition that the secularization characteristic of modernity (the rationalization of capitalism associated by Weber with the Protestant ethic and biblical monotheism) is a typical phenomenon of the Christian world; or through another paradox, namely the acknowledgment that the very idea of a cultural pluralism exists and developed within a specific culture, the Western one.

To be sure, Eurocentrism is the classic form taken by the idea of cultural pluralism in Western modernity, and it is no longer tenable because it placed cultures on an evolutionary trajectory whose highest point was the Christian civilization of the West. Pagan peoples were to be converted to Christianity and primitive societies were to become modern, meaning that they had to model themselves on Western ones, which were understood to be secular, liberal, and democratic. This evolutionary vision of human history, led by the ideal of emancipation as Westernization, modernization, and Christianization, was undermined not only, or primarily, by theoretical reasons. Rather, this image of the meaning of universal history became untenable because of the fall of colonialism and of the many forms of imperialism.

If today we can acknowledge that Christianity no longer presents itself as an obvious means of overcoming intercultural conflicts, this is due primarily to the erosion of the universalizing certainty of modern Western reason, which translated and secularized the Judeo-Christian faith in a divine plan of salvation—albeit unconsciously. Today, the aspect of Christian thought that always saw in this sec-

ular translation a betrayal and abandonment of the truth takes pleasure in the floundering of Western “rationalism.” However, the main consequence of this floundering is that Christianity tends to present itself more as involved in conflict than as a factor of reconciliation. The issue is all the more urgent since when we speak of Christianity we also speak of liberal society, of the West, and of modern democracy. True, the claim to universalism made by Christian civilization was clouded by and mixed up with the aims of colonialism and imperialism. But must all forms of universalism—the dream of a universal human civilization—come to an end, along with colonialism and imperialism? My argument is the following: (a) there are indications today that many Christian communities (various churches and confessions) share the widespread temptation to oppose universalism, which in modernity was complicit with the Eurocentrism of Western politics, with forms of closure ranging from various types of communitarianism (with their implication of a kind of cultural apartheid) to fundamentalism proper and its often violent outcomes; (b) in the belief that it can thus escape the perverse outcomes of modern rationalism, secularization, and so on, Christianity renounces its civilizing mission. Christianity can retrieve this mission, though no longer in its evolutionary and imperialist forms, only if it recovers its profound solidarity with the destiny of modernization.

Today, the choice facing Christianity (and I am quite aware of the generic meaning of this term: do I mean the Catholic Church? Christian churches? the thought of believers? The answer is all of the above, to some extent) is the following: either it embraces the destiny of modernity (and of its crisis, its transition to postmodernity), or, on the contrary, it claims to be outside it. If the latter option is chosen—and there are signs that this is a temptation—Christianity renounces being a world and a civilization, to

become what perhaps it originally was, a sect among other sects and an objective factor of social disruption among others.

To embrace the destiny of modernity and of the West means mainly to recognize the profoundly Christian meaning of secularization. I return to the observation made earlier, namely that the lay space of modern liberalism is far more religious than liberalism and Christian thought are willing to recognize. One of the first consequences of this observation is that it does not make sense for Christianity to situate itself in the new space of intercultural conflicts by assuming a strong identity. Rather, Christianity's vocation consists in deepening its own physiognomy as source and condition for the possibility of secularity.

What I am trying to argue (though with difficulty, since the problem is not a linear one) is that the postmodern dissolution of metanarratives (to use Lyotard's expression)—the idea that the universality of reason characteristic of modernity has been discredited—leads Christianity to see itself as merely an internal element in the conflict among cultures, religions, and world views. It seems to me that a religiously inspired communitarianism, and fundamentalisms in their different forms (including that which sometimes appears in the official teachings of the Catholic Church), correspond to this new attitude, which is legitimized by the fact that it no longer needs to reckon with the imperialist and colonial legacies of Enlightenment universalism and rationalism. As contemporary hermeneutics, along with the existentialism that inspired it (from Heidegger to Gadamer and Pareyson), teaches, the condition for any authentic dialogue is that every interlocutor assume explicitly his own involvement by acknowledging to himself and to the other interlocutor his own prejudices, or more generally his own identity, without assuming at the outset that he knows more about the subject matter or that he might lead the dialogue toward predictable outcomes

that he knows in advance to be “true” (this is why, for example, many hermeneutic philosophers are suspicious of a certain concept of the psychoanalytic dialogue that does not presuppose a perfect symmetry between the two interlocutors). In placing itself as an interlocutor with equal rights with respect to other cultures, Christianity should not forget that among the features of its heritage there is also universalism, namely the awareness of a plurality of cultures and of a lay space where these can confront one another. To become an authentic interlocutor in a cultural dialogue, Christianity cannot put aside this essential feature of its heritage and identity; it must present itself as a bearer of the idea of secularity for the sake of its own specific authenticity. This is the very idea of the universalism of reason, emptied of its contingent—though weighty and deeply rooted—complicity with modern colonialism and imperialism. However, this means that instead of “identifying itself” as a religion among others, thereby strengthening its distinctive character in dogma, moral preaching, and disciplinary cohesion, Christianity should develop its lay vocation, which is already visible in that in European modernity it made possible, and promoted, the birth of the lay orientation. Here it is less a matter of acknowledging an accidental, secularized character of Christianity than of acknowledging one of its essential traits that distinguishes Christianity from other religions: that from the outset it was deeply marked by a missionary element, explicit in Jesus’ summon to the apostles to preach the Gospel to all creatures. In modernity, the form of this missionary ideal was an alliance with European imperialism, often not experienced as a tragic necessity. At the same time, Christian universalism, in the wake of the terrifying experience of the European religious wars, led to the discovery of the idea of tolerance and to the invention of a “lay” space, where different religious and nonreligious positions that came to the surface in modern society could freely confront

one another. The point was, and still is, to grasp the Christian proclamation—based on Jesus’ sayings, “give unto Caesar” and “my kingdom is not of this world”—less, or not exclusively, as the end of all (other) false and lying gods than as a legitimate space for different religious experiences. Indeed, it is not rare to find among thinkers who profess to be Christian without reservations an interpretation of Christ’s incarnation that legitimates all the purely natural symbols of divinity. If God is incarnate in Jesus, it means that he is not so radically far apart from the natural, human world, and that truth may thus be found in the idolatry of many pagan religions as well.

Christianity frees itself from complicity with the imperialist ideals of European modernity in the wake of a series of historical experiences in which the former colonized nations turned against their “Christian” dominators in the name, too, of a more authentic interpretation of the biblical message. Christianity was forced to recover its lay inclination—to present itself as the promoter of a free dialogical space for religions, world views, ideal dispositions, and other cultures—because in its missionary vocation it had to confront new, unheard of historical experiences. Christianity cannot realize its missionary vocation within the new order of relations among nations and different peoples and cultures by stressing its own doctrinal, moral, and disciplinary specificity. Instead, it can take part in a conflictual or comparative dialogue with other cultures and religions by appealing to its specific lay orientation (since the same stress is not found in those other cultures and religions). This proposal could be summed up with the slogan “from universality to hospitality.” Indeed, the diffusion of fundamentalist positions or of forms of communitarian apartheid shows clearly that in the Babel-like world of pluralism, cultural and religious identities are destined to move toward fanaticism unless they explicitly develop in a spirit of weakness. Hospitality (I am thinking here of a

beautiful recent lecture by Jacques Derrida) is not realized if not as a placement of oneself in the hands of one's guest, that is, an entrustment of oneself to him. In intercultural or interreligious dialogue, this signifies acknowledging that the other might be right. If Christian identity, applying the principle of charity, takes the shape of hospitality in the dialogue between religions and cultures, it must limit itself almost entirely to listening, and thus giving voice to the guests.

I am aware that the thesis I am putting forth here is controversial and has many implications. Nevertheless, the task facing the Christian world (the West) today is the recovery of its universalizing function without any colonial, imperialist, or Eurocentric implications. It is difficult to imagine that this task might be accomplished by stressing its dogmatic, ethical, and disciplinary specificity. One might reasonably argue that this stress does not correspond to the content of Christian doctrine, but depends rather on a certain historical inertia of the churches insofar as they are worldly institutions. The other path open to Christianity is to recover its universalizing function by stressing its missionary inclination as hospitality, and as the religious foundation (paradoxical as this might be) of the laity (i.e., institutions, civil society, and religious individuals). To return to the example mentioned a moment ago, Christians cannot claim the right to expose the crucifix in public schools and at the same time adopt it as a sign of a particular, highly dogmatic religion. Or, Christmas can continue to be celebrated in Western societies as a holiday for all, but then it makes no sense to complain that it has become too lay, too mundane, that is, that it has been deprived of its original, authentic meaning. In the end, also, the prohibition of the *chador* in French public schools can be justified precisely because in that context it is an affirmation of a strong identity, a kind of profession of fundamentalism. By contrast, in our society the crucifix has become an al-

most obvious—and hence unobtrusive—sign, which allows for the continued existence of a lay orientation of which it only underscores the religious origin within the context of a development toward secularization. It is precisely by appealing to this generic meaning—one that offers openings and possibilities—that the crucifix can claim its right to be accepted as a universal symbol in a lay society. If world religions, primarily Christianity, are determined to present themselves as strong identities, the only option for liberal society will be to manifest its secularity by further reducing the visibility of all religious symbols in civic life, so as to not arouse reactions from this or that minority or from “other” religions and cultures. Among other things, this would ultimately force us to close most Western museums and to renounce the very cultural traditions of the West, which are so thick with—and inseparable from—religious symbols. By contrast, we should promote a free and intense coexistence of multiple symbolic universes in a spirit of hospitality that well expresses the lay orientation of Western culture, and its deeply religious origin—perhaps taking the museum, with its juxtaposition of different styles, tastes, and cultures, as a symbolic model of democracy. Yet to reach this goal, it is necessary that the world religions, and Christianity in the first place, no longer take the dogmatic and fundamentalist forms that have characterized them to date. In this sense, too, one might say, against all narrowly lay expectations, that the renewal of civic life in the Western world in the epoch of multiculturalism is mainly a problem of the renewal of the religious life.



*The Christian Message and the Dissolution
of Metaphysics*

IT MAY BE possible to say that, in a very broad perspective, the two thousand years that separate us from the mysterious event to which our calendars refer can be understood as the progressive diminishing of the validity of a famous saying, “*Amicus Plato sed magis amica veritas*” (attributed by ancient biographers to Aristotle). We might recall that this expression is found in Dostoyevsky, too. When evoking the choice between Christ and truth (*The Demons*, part II, chapter VII), Satov assigns it to Stavrogin. However, in a letter, Dostoyevsky pronounces it in his own name. The sentence cannot be denied or overturned only in the name of love for Christ. Indeed, Dostoyevsky represents a paradoxical case, since beginning with Jesus’ words “*ego sum via, veritas et vita*,” the inclination of Christian thought has been to identify Christ with truth (in the classical sense of truth as the accurate and objective description of reality), thus denying the possibility that there might be any difference between the two terms. This might be the reason why Dostoyevsky has an exceptional place in

Christian thought.¹ Apart from him, the classical tendency of Christian thought has been to identify truth with Christ. If truth has the power to free us, it is only because knowledge of the real would enable us to free ourselves (but from what? surely not from truth-reality, no matter how burdensome or disagreeable that might be). Redemption (a prayer of the Roman breviary recites, "*Redimisti nos Domine, Deus Veritatis*") would consist in seeing Being itself: *Amor dei intellectualis*, to use a term of Spinoza. Indeed, the traditional idea of eternal life as the (face to face) contemplation of God has been developed in the Spinozan sense, identifying the blessed life with the perfect knowledge of geometry. Was this the reason the second person of the Holy Trinity incarnated and sacrificed himself on the cross?

It seems clear enough from these observations that Dostoyevsky, with his paradoxical choice for Christ, even at the price of truth, is the Christian thinker who is most faithful to the meaning of the gospel. Even more than in Dostoyevsky, though, faithfulness to the gospel should be sought in Nietzsche, and especially in his announcement of the death of God. The God who has been killed by his followers is only—and rightly—the moral God (the supreme guarantor of the world's [geometrical] order who made Socrates say that the righteous man has nothing to fear in this life or in the life after death). Nietzsche's announcement, therefore, is not merely a repetition, in a literal sense, of the biblical story of the crucifixion; it is also the most radical expression of Dostoyevsky's paradox.

Nietzsche does not formulate this paradox as a moral choice to which every individual exposes himself on the way to salvation. Rather, he sees it—and this is the point I wish to stress here—as the very meaning of the history of Europe, of the West, or of "Christian modernity." The death of the moral God marks the impossibility of preferring truth to friendship, because the meaning of that death

is that there is no “objective,” ontological truth that might be upheld as anything other than friendship, will to power, or subjective bond. Those who pronounce “*magis amica veritas*” do so out of love for another, or perhaps for themselves, for the tradition that speaks in them or for the “*human, all too human*” reasons that Nietzsche so meticulously analyzed, following in the footsteps of the French moralists. These are: friendship and will, or, to speak in Pascal’s terms, “the reasons of the heart.”

If *European nihilism* (which is the title of a famous fragment written in Lenzer Heide in the summer of 1887) means the impossibility of believing in an objective world order, which would justify faithfulness to truth above and beyond friendship and hostility, then Nietzsche does not see (does not want to see, or perhaps cannot see because of his own hostilities: he was the son of a pastor and grew up in the shadows of the Church, as one of his autobiographical fragments says) that nihilism is not confined to his own understanding of the death of God. It comprises also the death of Jesus narrated by the Gospels, or what Heidegger calls the end of metaphysics. This end, as we know, comes to completion in Nietzsche’s nihilism and in the historical phenomenon that the Nietzschean doctrine acknowledges, describes, and announces. From the Nietzschean-Heideggerian perspective in which I place myself, nihilism is the loss of credence in an objective truth in favor of a perspective that conceives of truth as an effect of power in the manifold senses of this expression: as a scientific experiment that realizes the *principium reddendae rationis*, its foundation the active will of the subjects who set up the experiment and of those who within a historical paradigm, which is not necessarily arbitrary, adhere to its validity; as an ideology that members of a social class hold to be true; and as a lie invented by monks in order to justify power and social discipline.

To what extent can one consider the consummation of

objective truth in different manifestations of friendship, and therefore of the reasons of the heart, to be an effect of the death of Christ, that is, as a result of the mysterious event that lies at the basis of our civilization and of modern calculation of time?

The author who can best help us answer this question, or one to whom we should refer, is Wilhelm Dilthey. He clearly took over Hegel's legacy, though he updated it in order to soften the most strict and systematic aspects of Hegel's philosophy of history. In the second volume of his uncompleted book, *Einleitung in die Geisteswissenschaften*, Dilthey retraces two stages within the history of European metaphysics: that of the ancients and that of the moderns. The latter was destined to end with the dissolution of metaphysics accomplished by the Kantian critique and its developments up to Dilthey's historicism.

Now, what distinguishes ancient metaphysics from modern metaphysics is the "turning" accomplished by Christianity's advent, which shifted the interest of philosophy from the natural world to the inwardness of man. For Dilthey, Platonism is the emblem of ancient metaphysics, even though it is not naturalism in the strict sense of the word. Its distinctive value lies in Plato's concept of Being (as Heidegger would say later on, since his vision of the history of metaphysics is deeply influenced by Dilthey) as a visible form—*idea*, *eidos*—and thus as an external "phenomenon," placed as an objective form before the mind's eye. In contrast, Christianity shifts the attention of thought inward, putting at the center the will rather than the intellect. The *Einleitung* says:

For the Greek mind, knowing was mirroring an objective thing in the intelligence. Now [i.e., in Christianity], experience becomes the focal point of all the interests of the new communities; but this is just simple awareness of what is given in person-

ality and in consciousness of the self. . . . With the enormous interest they generate, experiences of the will and of the heart swallow up every other object of knowledge. . . . If this community faith had immediately developed a science perfectly appropriate to it, that science would have to rest on a foundation ultimately resting on inner experience.²

To sum up, briefly: Christianity is the condition that paved the way for the dissolution of metaphysics and for its replacement by gnoseology—in Dilthey's terms, by Kantianism. The principles that inspired Descartes and Kant—the emphasis on the subject, the foundation of knowledge on a self-certain interiority—are the same ones that hold sway in modern philosophy. The latter remained, for a long time, a kind of metaphysics dominated by an objectivistic vision of interiority itself, because the new principle of subjectivity introduced by Christianity did not immediately succeed. “But this inner structure which, with respect to scientific grounding, occupies a place between Christianity and knowledge that grows out of inner experience, did not produce a corresponding scientific grounding in the Middle Ages. The reason for this was the preponderant power of ancient culture, within which Christianity now began to assert itself gradually.”³

Saint Augustine clearly represents the conflict between the novelty of Christian interiority and the hegemony of Greek aesthetic or “visual” objectivism. He combines the self-assurance of the soul's relation to God with a theory of the *veritates aeternae* derived from Platonism and neo-Platonism: “the soul sees truth through its own self, not by means of the body and its sense organs. We are right back in the middle of Plato's metaphysics again, which we thought we had left behind us.”⁴ “*On the other hand*,” writes Dilthey, “there are *elements* in Augustine's inner experience

which *transcend this Platonizing connection* between man's intellect, the world, and God—namely, in the *veritates aeternae* . . . a component . . . going beyond the thought of antiquity.”⁵ (Let me point out that this is not the traditional opposition, in Christian thought, between Platonism and Aristotelianism; rather, it is an opposition between the remnants of Greek thought that also happened to be Platonic and the “Kantian” novelty of Christianity.) What takes place in Augustine's thought occurs at different stages of development in the whole history of Christianity from the Middle Ages to modernity. A struggle between Christianity's offering of a new possibility to thought and metaphysics' endurance goes on up to Kant, who draws the anti-metaphysical implications of the inaugural move of the Christian message. The reasons for the endurance of metaphysics are manifold and intricate. Sometimes Dilthey attributes them, with respect to Augustine, to the latter's personal history, which is marked by the influence of neo-Platonism. But the endurance of metaphysics in Augustine, as in all the Church fathers and medieval thinkers, may be understood above all in light of the social and political responsibility the Church had to take over after the fall of the Roman Empire. Indeed, the remnants of the ancient social institutions, and the culture they expressed, rested on the shoulders of the Church. Furthermore, the Church developed into a rigid structure, which was unavoidably grounded on an objectivistic metaphysics and on scientific knowledge's claims about the natural world—as Galileo's case shows.

This view of the history of European thought as a struggle between the principles of metaphysics—inwardness, will, certitude of the *cogito*—which Christianity introduced into the world and the naturalist-visual (aesthetic) objectivism of Greek culture deeply marks Heidegger's vision of metaphysics' survival and dissolution. Let me stress that—more explicitly for Heidegger, but also for Dilthey—

there is no question of a struggle between the “natural” (or, paradoxically, “objective”) truth of Christian subjectivism and a metaphysics that would reveal itself by falsifying this authentic truth. The substance of the Christian announcement is not Christ’s revelation of an eternal truth but rather an actual historical event. It is, then, a struggle between two historical possibilities, or perhaps between two versions of “friendship.”

Beginning again with Dilthey is, in my view, essential in order to understand how Christianity could be taken as the starting point of the modern dissolution of metaphysics. It will be sufficient to acknowledge—and this is the meaning of Heidegger’s existentialism in *Being and Time*—that Kantianism is still a kind of Augustinianism, namely a claim to trace the inner certitude back to an ahistorical, “natural,” and therefore objective structure (the Kantian transcendental, which was already criticized by Dilthey). Hence, the Nietzsche of the death of God and the Heidegger of *Ereignis* are the most radical heirs of the anti-metaphysical principle that Christ brought into the world. Note also that there is a deeply Christian element in Dilthey’s concluding remarks on the history and dissolution of metaphysics. Indeed, Dilthey writes that whereas metaphysics as a science has become impossible, “the meta-physical [sic] element of our *life* as personal experience, that is, as moral-religious truth, remains. . . . But experiences of a person’s will are exempt from a universally valid presentation, which would be coercive and obligatory for every other intellect.”⁶ “But,” Dilthey goes on, “whatever they will turn up, wherever a man by his will breaks through the structure of perception, desire, impulse, and pleasure, and is no longer self-interested, here we have the meta-physical [sic] element, which the history of metaphysics we have described has merely reflected in countless images. For metaphysical science is a historically limited phenomenon, but the meta-physical [sic] consciousness of

the person is eternal.”⁷ It would be difficult, though not impossible, to read this passage as a critical reference to metaphysical objectivism’s survival in Schopenhauer’s negation of the will. Yet the passage is quite ambiguous. On the one hand, one might conjecture that the negation of the self and of the will is a radical mode of showing preference for the object rather than the subject (indeed, this is Adorno’s criticism of Heidegger in the *Negative Dialectics*). On the other hand, the tone of the passage indicates that Dilthey sees this “eternal metaphysics,” which manifests itself in every overcoming of the will to live, as a positive element, that is, as a metaphysical remnant in an eminent sense, which cannot be overcome by our post-Kantian modernity. It was a spirit of negation of will that inspired also Heidegger’s notion of *Gelassenheit* (abandonment or serenity). The same ambiguity, though, can be seen in Heidegger’s view of the end of metaphysics as the triumph of modern subjectivism and voluntarism, which is the last stage of the forgetting of Being, though it is at the same time the first *Aufblitzen* of *Ereignis*, the first illumination of the event of Being, as Heidegger says in *Identity and Difference*.⁸

Why, then, *Amicus Plato*? Why prefer friendship to truth? We find here the last manifestation of the struggle between the enduring force of the objective residue of Greek metaphysics and the power of Christian novelty. Briefly, we could say that Nietzschean nihilism and Heideggerian ontologism (as expressed by Lévinas’s critique of Heidegger) blend Christianity with Greek Platonism. This is the same kind of blend that Dilthey saw in Augustine. (We could ask whether, in different manners, both thinkers express similar personal and psychological elements. Nietzsche, the son of a pastor, rebelled against his father’s authority, his sister’s, and so on; Heidegger distanced himself from the Catholic Church at the very beginning of his academic career. All this is mixed with issues of politics and

power: I am referring to Nietzsche's last writings and to Heidegger's involvement in Nazism.) To a different degree and for reasons that are only vaguely similar to Augustine's, Nietzsche and Heidegger remain captive to Greek objectivism and refuse to develop fully the implications of Christianity's antimetaphysical revolution. These cannot be fully developed without recourse to charity. In other words, only friendship, explicitly recognized as the decisive truth factor, can prevent the thought of the end of metaphysics from lapsing into a reactive—and often reactionary—nihilism, to use Nietzsche's expression.

Here I shall limit myself to a simple sketch—which, I hope, is suggestive enough, though in need of clarification. In my view, the central role of the Other (here we touch on the theological objectivism in Lévinas's thought) in the different theories of Lévinas, Habermas's philosophy of communication, and Davidson's use of the very term *charity* confirms my hypothesis concerning the central role of the Christian *caritas*.

Why, then, should we not prefer Lévinas, Habermas, and Davidson to the dubious authority of controversial thinkers such as Nietzsche and Heidegger? One might answer that only Nietzsche and Heidegger have offered a more rigorous philosophical foundation—by reconstructing the history and dissolution of metaphysics (which can be found also in Nietzsche's chapter, "How the Real World Became a Fable," in *Twilight of the Idols*)—than that advanced by Habermas and Lévinas, who are also well disposed to charity. To put it more explicitly: friendship can become the principle and factor of truth only if thought leaves behind any claim to an objective, universal, and apodictic foundation. Outside of an authentic opening of Being as event, the Lévinasian other is always exposed to the risk of being dethroned by the Other (with a capital letter). Once again, it is a truth that justifies friendship for Plato only by eliminating him as a historical individual. A similar

argument holds for Habermas, for his “nonopaque” communication, which operates as a normative horizon, is not grounded on respect for the other as such. Rather, it reduces the other and the self to an idea of rational “transparency.” Yet even if Habermas’s philosophy is not modeled on a Kantian type of rationalist metaphysics, or precisely because it claims not to be, it is only in the last resort a colonization of the life-world by strategic rationality, which holds sway in techno-science.

Christian preaching on charity is not exclusively an ethical or edifying consequence of the “objective” truth of revelation about our nature as children of God. Rather, it is a call that arises from the historical event of incarnation (it is historical not in the sense that it is a “real” phenomenon but rather insofar as, in its *Wirkungsgeschichte* [effective history], it is constitutive of our existence) and that speaks of the nihilistic vocation of Being. It is a teleology in which every ontic structure is weakened in favor of ontological Being, namely the *Verbum*, Logos, Word shared in the Dialogue (*Gespräch*) that constitutes us as historical beings.

Truth as charity and Being as event (*Ereignis*) are closely related. The central role of the Other in contemporary philosophy acquires its full meaning only if it is placed in the context of the dissolution of metaphysics. Only this condition prevents thought from lapsing into a mere edifying or pragmatic moralism. Notwithstanding the impreciseness of this provisional conclusion, I believe, one should begin here a reflection on what remains to be recollected and undertaken of the mysterious event that took place two thousand years ago.

Violence, Metaphysics, and Christianity

IT IS THE paradox of our epoch that we are called to reflect on the link between violence and metaphysics, and on its presence in the history of Christianity, precisely when war is being waged to eradicate war and violence employed to eliminate violence (e.g., of Serbs against Kosovars, or vice versa). The idea that violence might put an end to violence (since every war is supposedly the last) shows that violence ultimately draws from the need, the resolve, and the desire to reach and be taken up into the first principle. I do not know whether this might be the original sin. Yet it seems certain that the almost innate need, which metaphysics addresses, to grasp the origin (*arche*) is deeply linked to *hubris*, that is, to the desire to own one's existence completely. Hence the predominance in humans of laws of survival that "justify" violence where evil dwells. From this perspective, the contemporary interpretation of original sin (which is also found in the Church fathers) as a violation linked to the sphere of sexuality seems plausible. However, this is only because the will of affirmation and the will to survive reveal themselves here in their most

elemental sense: in how sexuality is lived immediately and psychologically, and in its place in the reproduction of biological life. A number of corollaries can be drawn here, for example, the “blessing” of sexuality in marriage, which grants that institution the same legitimacy as a just war. It is a justice that can be called into question, that conceals violence—in the case of sex, the will of affirmation and the desire of fulfilling life—with the principle “one must live on,” always invoked to justify the perpetration of the worst foul deeds. Furthermore, from this perspective, could the purely ludic use of sexuality be the principal way in which culture tried to diminish the original violence of the law of survival, as if to displace the instincts of self-affirmation and supremacy from war to sport? In any case, the sexual morality long preached by the (Catholic) Church, which sees sexuality mainly, or exclusively, as a means of reproduction, involves considerably less respect and attention for the other than the ludic, seductive, and aesthetic sexuality of Don Juan.

These are just a few possible examples of how, through an intricate, long, and often complex chain of influences—which needs to be reexamined—metaphysical violence affects deeply many of the most controversial aspects of “Christian morality.” Metaphysical violence is, generally, all identification between law and nature, which has dominated the traditional teaching of the Church. The command to love one’s neighbor, above all one’s enemy, appears so barely reasonable as to require a metaphysical grounding in the more natural feeling of fraternal love, of love for one’s own—those who are bound to us by virtue of birth. Any morality that ignores Hume’s Law tends to be violent. Hume’s Law, recall, refers to the observation made by the British philosopher that it is not possible to move from the description of a natural behavior to the assertion of a norm without presupposing another thesis (i.e., that what happens in nature is good in itself).

It is true that the great tradition of natural legal thought always saw itself as reason's struggle against arbitrary violence, and that the Church's concern with the *preambula fidei* was experienced mostly as a preoccupation with dialogue, a way of drawing closer to nonbelievers that did not presuppose their adherence to Christ's message. It was a way of making the Christian message acceptable. However, it is equally true that the tradition of natural legal thought was conceived and practiced as a way of legitimating the "reasonable" use of force, for example to authorize rebellion against a tyrant. And the reasonableness of the *preambula fidei* often has justified coercing people to believe on the ground that human reason itself demands the acceptance of faith. Contemporary Catholic teaching is in line with this when it demands that the laws of the state must conform to the laws that the Church claims to be "natural."

The point, however, is not to discuss the advantages or disadvantages of the tradition of natural law. Perhaps the idea of natural rights had the historical function of diminishing violence in times of extreme cultural fragmentation, hence the idea of a "natural" brotherhood of men. It would be interesting to ask when and how the idea of natural rights, and that of loving one's neighbor on the ground of a natural "brotherhood" of men, fell into crisis and began to reveal their violent foundations. In all likelihood, we would discover that this transformation is bound up with the same principle that, according to Heidegger, has put an end to metaphysics: the fact of its becoming, from the ideal prefigurations of reality's rationalization, an effective law for the functioning of the rational world of technology—and the power grounded in it.

Therefore, violence in Christianity maintains itself and rules as long as it maintains its multiple links to metaphysics. Wilhelm Dilthey, in *Introduction to the Human Sciences* (1883), had argued already that the beginning of the end

of metaphysics (understood as the identification of Being with the objectivity of the visible form, that is, as the intellectual vision of ideas with the stability of reality's essential structures) coincided with the advent of Christianity. According to Dilthey, metaphysics lasted well after Kant because the philosophical meaning of the new Christian concern with interiority, subjectivity, and, ultimately, freedom emerged only after a long period during which the metaphysical objectivism of antiquity continued to prevail. This was because the Church inherited the historical structures of antiquity, and in order to ensure its survival had to preserve that culture. Thus Saint Augustine is at once the philosopher of the *Confessions* and the bishop who exercises historical and political power. What Dilthey advances as a purely factual explanation for the survival of metaphysics in Christianity (which lasts more or less as long as the temporal power of the Church and of the churches does) should be broadened and radicalized in the direction suggested by Rene Girard. According to him, it is the survival of the victim-based mechanism, albeit in attenuated form, that explains the recurrence of violence in the history of Christianity. To complete Girard's argument, we learn from Heidegger that what Girard calls the victim-based mechanism is metaphysical objectivism. While Girard sees its nature in the deep-rooted presence of mimetic violence within individuals and human societies (the original sin?), for Heidegger it is the impossibility of overcoming metaphysics. Metaphysics cannot be overcome by a human decision until Being addresses humanity in a different manner (only a God can save us?). What should not be lost in these intersecting interpretations (victim-based mechanism and metaphysics) is, too, the relationship with structures of power.

In my opinion, it is relevant to note here that the hardening of the Church's position on metaphysical-natural

ethics manifests itself in the form of a struggle to uphold certain principles in the laws of states. My argument is not that the Church's defense of (what it believes to be natural) law in matters of family ethics and, more recently, of bioethics is an expression of its will to retain the temporal power that over the centuries it has seen erode. Instead, I want to call attention to the fact that the defense of these principles and the manner of their justification (as natural principles, rather than as explicitly Christian theses) correspond to a specific conception of the Church in the world. This is the figure of a structure organized hierarchically and vertically that is ultimately authoritarian. The pope's encyclical *Fides et Ratio* (1998) bears witness to this conception: it invites philosophy to put trust in a reason that is free to search for the truth. Could anyone read *Fides et Ratio* in a different manner? The encyclical's novelty lies in its explicitly stated purpose of "recruiting" in defense of Christian naturalist metaphysics the same philosophy that in the past few centuries, by practicing free inquiry, has increasingly moved away from metaphysics.

To return to the main argument, violence found its way into Christianity when Christianity made an alliance with metaphysics as the "science of Being as being," that is, as the knowledge of first principles. The reasons for this alliance and the circumstances behind it are many, beginning with the responsibilities the Church inherited from the dissolution of the Roman Empire, as the only remaining temporal power. Another reason is the classical identification of Christian existence with the philosophical existence: the human being can realize humanity fully by rising to the knowledge of the first principle (following the model of Plato and Plotinus), to be taken up into it. In this view, the commandment of charity appears totally inconsequential. What ultimately matters is knowledge of the truth, which involves detachment from the sensible good so that strug-

gle for survival and conflict with others may be reduced. However, the positive meaning of forgoing violence is not an (ethical) openness to the other.

The idea that morality has to do with the respect of natural law belongs to the same tradition. It claims that perfection lies in conforming to the first principle and is persuaded, without question or explanation, of the first principle's force. Here *hubris* and submission are inextricably blended and in contradiction, to reveal the neurotic mindset of metaphysics—as Nietzsche correctly pointed out. We are aware that whenever we reflect on the possibility of overcoming metaphysics we encounter a number of theoretical, ethical, and existential difficulties that deeply involve us. The analysis of the metaphysical and violent roots of our culture could put in question even the “*factum*” of the categorical imperative that, according to Kant, speaks within us.

How shall we rethink Christian ethics and metaphysics if we concede that (a) the idea of perfection—as a movement of ascendance toward and mystic identification with the first principle (Plotinus)—is the manifestation of *hubris*, as well as a source of further violence (through the imposition of the natural law against the will of men); and (b) the idea that the moral law can be grounded only upon nature as *factum*—a given beyond which questions cannot be asked—is a contradictory and radically violent thought? (Why should I no longer ask why? And if nature is the law, of necessity it must realize itself, thus making the imposition of a command utterly meaningless.)

Even just posing these hypotheses and the questions arising from them destabilizes many of the most firmly rooted structures of our mindset. How to think of perfection if not as the identification with Being itself, God, the supreme principle? And how to think of metaphysics, or in any case essential knowledge, if not as the theoretical appropriation of first principles? How to ground the law if

not in an incontrovertible, unquestionable, and given structure, which as such can also legitimate the use of force?

For Heidegger, the difficulty of formulating answers to these kinds of questions makes clear the impossibility of going beyond metaphysics. Metaphysics cannot be overcome but only *verwunden*—accepted, distorted, and continued in ironic directions that are known to be provisional. The same may be said of Girard's thesis, according to which sacrifice cannot not be repeated, even in the purely symbolic forms of ritual like the Mass, precisely because otherwise mimetic violence risks unleashing itself again in unmediated forms of bloody conflict. This recognition, in its Heideggerian and in its Girardian form, does not exempt us from the effort to understand how we can or must continue the saving act of revelation, which manifests the violent nature of the victim-based mechanism and of metaphysics, thus reducing anew the violence of institutions, including ecclesiastical ones. The difference between Girard and Heidegger, or even between Heidegger and his hermeneutic followers, can be explained by their different conceptions of the symbolization of sacrifice, or the meaning of *Verwindung*. This argument can be reasonably developed in reference to secularization. Even Weber's interpretation of Christian ethics as a rationally organized economy is perhaps a means of symbolizing sacrifice. Above all, the establishment of liberal principles in a liberal society and in the political organization (do anything you will as long as it does not infringe upon the freedom of all others) is a secular symbolizing of the Christian message.

If we accept Girard's thesis that the natural sacred is violence, and that sacrifice is the victimization of a scapegoat against whom all the bloody expressions of the mimetic crisis are unleashed, then it seems difficult to escape from the logic of secularization as the continuation of the Christian revelation's saving action. Someone has leveled the objection—I am referring to debates in which I have

recently participated, but it would be equally possible to cite authoritative printed sources in support of this position—that the idea of sacrifice as violence excludes the possibility of self-sacrifice. Jesus is at the same time victim and priest; therefore, so the argument runs, he is not subjected to violence by another. Rather, he inflicts violence upon himself, thereby escaping from the victim-based logic described by Girard. To this objection, we can reply that: (a) one can understand that Jesus had to sacrifice himself for the love of humanity, even as an act of free choice, only if one grants that a sacrifice was required of him. If the remission of sins requires sacrifice, it confirms the logic of the victim-based mechanism, for the God who demands the satisfaction of “justice” is still conceived of as the violent God of natural religions; (b) if Jesus’ free sacrifice was inspired by something other than the victim-based logic, then we must take seriously the idea that it demands to be understood as kenotic salvation. This does not imply salvation by means of kenosis, for if glory had to be reached through humiliation and suffering we would act in full accordance with the victim-based logic. Kenosis is not a means of ransom but ransom itself. To me, this appears the most reasonable reading of the message of incarnation. It might be considered a “nihilist” reading, but only by those who still want to conceive of Being metaphysically in terms of imposition, stability, and the full evidence of the present. These are precisely the attributes found in Aristotle’s pure act or in Parmenides’ Being, which stand radically opposed to the idea of Being as a creation of a free and loving God. The metaphysical God, whom Christian theology thought necessary to acknowledge as its “natural” foundation, also poses problems, such as the idea of predestination, that are ultimately unresolvable. This requires a theodicy that is always vulnerable to the irony of Voltaire’s *Candide*, and that to this day inspires the naturalist—authoritarian and inefficient—ethics found in the teaching of the pope.



Does this mean then that if we seek to follow Christian revelation more radically against the logic of metaphysics and of the victim-based mechanism, there are no limits or rational guides? Perhaps yes, we might answer. One remains at the mercy of the event, that is, one is entrusted to positivity as an occurrence of creation and revelation, rather than as an expression of natural structures. Why should we place our trust in the certainty of metaphysical evidence rather than in the interpretation of the divine Word, given by the community of believers and freely by each individual believer, which changes in accordance with the becoming of history? This question can have only two answers. Either God is immutable—but then this is the God of metaphysics to whom one cannot attribute the creation of the world in time, much less the loving creation of free beings—or metaphysical evidence is safe from the possibility of freedom, since it all is entrusted to the hands of an authority once and for all, and this authority must grant it legitimacy even when rationally free inquiry discovers that it is baseless. These are not two alternative replies. Indeed, in the Church's ancient and recent history, these answers are inseparable. For this reason, too, their prevalence in our contemporary world cannot be attributed to the perverse cunning of priests. Rather, it must be seen as inevitable, similarly to the persistence of the victim-based logic in Girard or of the impossibility of overcoming metaphysics in Heidegger. However, this does not mean that we should not prepare anew, through a radical critique, for the possible overcoming of metaphysics, even if only in the form of *Verwindung*. Salvation is not positively in our hands. Rather, we are called to be vigilant, so that we might not be fooled by the Antichrist.

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*Heidegger and Christian Existence*

HEIDEGGER'S RELATIONSHIP TO the Christian, and specifically Catholic, tradition is still to be thoroughly explored. Heidegger was steeped in Catholicism to the extent that his bishop subsidized his studies, and he was considered the bright promise of German Catholic thought at the beginning of his career. Perhaps this relationship to Christianity will appear in a new light after the release of more unpublished works in addition to those that have appeared in recent years. Among the latter, the "Einleitung in die *Phänomenologie der Religion*" (Introduction to the Phenomenology of Religion)¹ has a central place. This is a transcript of the course Heidegger taught at the University of Freiburg during the winter semester 1920, which appeared in 1995 in the *Gesamtausgabe*. As often happens with his lecture courses, Heidegger is much more comprehensible here than in the "written" texts. The importance of this "Einleitung" is not only that it anticipates clearly and effectively many themes of *Being and Time*, which thus appear in the subsequent elaboration of Heidegger's thought. What is more significant and striking is that the theme of

Being and Time is linked here *essentially* to a meditation on Christian experience, along with the idea of metaphysics as the forgetting of Being, which Heidegger would develop later. This Christian link is essential, especially if one keeps in mind the meaning Heidegger's writings give to the word *Wesen*. By this I mean that the main concepts of *Being and Time* appear unthinkable without reference to the Christian *Event*. Hence this link is of a historical and destinal character, and cannot be deduced analytically from the "concept" of Christianity.

The fundamental nature of the link must be emphasized, because it is precisely the historical (existential) character of the nexus between *Being and Time* and Christian experience that I want to address here. It becomes clear in the "Einleitung"—especially in the first part where Heidegger explores the question of the philosophical and phenomenological analysis of religious experience—that Christian experience is not one among other religious experiences from which the general meaning of religion might be abstracted. What distinguishes Heidegger's conception of phenomenology from that of his teacher, Husserl, is the idea that no knowledge of essences is given outside of the existential relation of the "subject" with its "object." This is already clear as well in another essay (a review of Karl Jaspers's *Psychologie der Weltanschauungen*) of the same period, which was published only in the third edition of the *Wegmarken*, released prior to Heidegger's death. In his review of the *Psychologie der Weltanschauungen*, Heidegger's main objection is that by limiting himself to a panoramic or "aesthetic" vision and to a typological classification of world views, Jaspers has forgotten the genuine philosophical aim stated at the beginning of his book, namely that of analyzing the world views in order to question his own, thereby involving himself thematically in the analysis. It is precisely on the basis of this methodological

principle that Heidegger turns to the question of a phenomenology of religion.

The apparently unjustified transition from the first part of the lecture course might be explained by assuming that Heidegger wants to remain faithful to the idea of philosophy that inspires him. There is an abrupt shift between the first part, punctuated by general and methodological observations that lead Heidegger to discuss contemporary theories of religion (from the perspective of an existential phenomenology), and the second part, where two Letters of Paul to the Thessalonians are analyzed in depth. This is a philosophy that does not approach its theme from an external angle but rather subsumes it within the framework of factic life-experience (*faktische Lebenserfahrung*),² which phenomenology cannot do without. Consider the following passages from Heidegger's review of Jaspers: "The path that leads to the 'things themselves' . . . is a genuine confrontation with the history that we ourselves 'are.'"³ It is difficult to say whether this approach is a kind of neutral methodological presupposition, imposed by the concern that phenomenology should be more radically or authentically scientific in a broad sense. This approach would then be applicable to all philosophical analysis, including of religion. By contrast, the very concept of factic life-experience might not be derived from the assumption of religious—and specifically Christian—experience as a model of an authentically radical philosophy. (Religious experience is above all one that cannot take place without a personal commitment, a response that may not be confined in its constitutive form to the objective grasping of a content.) After all, Heidegger seems to confirm such a hypothesis when he argues in the lecture course that the early Christian experience recovered through Paul consists of the experience of authentic temporality. We could say that here it is a matter of logical circles. But it is such circles

that make up factic reflection, which after all later will be theorized explicitly as the “hermeneutic circle.”

These few remarks already threaten to lead into a vortex, like the abysses of which the later Heidegger speaks. They suggest that it is not only the conceptual framework of *Being and Time* that is inseparable from the reflection on Christian experience but also Heidegger’s philosophical attitude as a whole. A phenomenologist like Husserl, or like one of his faithful disciples, easily understands that the concept of science invented by the Greeks has by now become an essential patrimony of humanity, as *The Crisis of the European Sciences* argues. They may think this without further analyzing the relationship between the historicity of this “invention” and the human essence from which it is said to have gradually become indistinguishable. This is a specific movement of thought typical of all Eurocentric philosophy of the West, which always has identified its own culture, in its historical becoming, with humanity—a humanity that supposedly revealed itself most completely in the West. This is the meaning of humanism, to which Heidegger turned in his 1946 “Letter on Humanism.” A close reading of the 1920 lectures suggests that, in Heidegger’s view, we cannot avoid conceiving of philosophy in Christian terms, while maintaining a clear knowledge that Christianity is an event—that is, fully embracing our concrete historicity instead of leaving it behind in order to turn to the vision of essence. Instead, we are to elaborate the factic life-experience into a critique of metaphysics and the later theme of the “history of Being.” Perhaps Heidegger’s insistence on terms like “*egheneto*” and “*eghenestai*” (I Thessalonians 1:5–7) in reading Paul refers to the possibility of such an “essential” dimension, understood as destiny and not as a universality in the sense of metaphysical abstractions. Such an insistence can be taken as a justification of the logical “leap” from the first to the second part of the course. If indeed Christian religious experience is recognizable as

(definitely more than) the model of an authentic experience of temporality—which insofar as it is our destiny (*Wesentlich*), we cannot avoid recognizing as the *only* authentic experience of temporality—it is because we, those who are set to study religious experience phenomenologically, have already “become,” that is, we have already come to know it (*oidate*) because we have received the announcement. We can express this observation in different ways: for example, by recognizing as a constitutive characteristic of religious experience—the one accessible to us—the fact that we can never begin by choosing among different religions, but must find ourselves already in a tradition, in a faith that we can certainly criticize or refute but not decide from scratch to accept or not. Perhaps this is a feature of all religious experience, but it is certain that in the case of Christianity, this has to do with the historicity of revelation and ultimately with the creation narrated in the Bible rather than with the anthropological data that see religion taught within the family, together with a mother tongue and the first rules of behavior. True, the having become of which Paul speaks consists of the transformation that has already taken place among the Thessalonians in response to his preaching; they learn from Paul what they already know. However, it is also clear that in Heidegger this has a broader meaning—insofar as authentic temporality is manifested as a tension between the “already” and the “not yet,” which is the structure of Christian eschatology. To reduce *egheneto* to the recent memory of Paul’s preaching implies a literal reading that Paul himself refutes (and that we, as interpreters, cannot ignore), since his first preaching to the Thessalonians is the announcement of what they already are by virtue of Christ’s redemption.

In what sense, then, does “recognizing oneself in what one already is” constitute the basis of an authentic experience of temporality? Recall that in the first part of the lecture course, Heidegger often evokes historicism as the

characteristic feature of our epoch, which manifests itself in a false mode of approaching reflections on religion (because it reduces religion to the historical reconstruction of religions, and of their histories). Historicism espouses a linear conception of time as the succession of instants within which events and things stand as objects that can be approached with an attitude of detachment, that is, “objectively,” because our historicity in turn consists of belonging again and again to always different instants along the trajectory of time (“Einleitung” 31ff). However, lived historicity is what Heidegger seeks to grasp with factic life-experience, and it is different than standing inside the flow of time. The authentic temporality of Christian experience appears as the solution to the problem, or at least as an alternative model to standing as simple presence inside the linear flow of time. *Eggheneto*, the already that constitutes the background against which Paul’s preaching is set in the Letters, is the having already happened of salvation through the death and resurrection of Christ. This salvation is not a “past” event in the horizontal-objective meaning of the term, in the sense that it is not completed and must be awaited as the eschatological event of the *parousia*. Let me point out that the difficulty in thinking through this experience of Christian temporality is not at all different from that encountered in reading passages of *Being and Time* on this theme, though in the latter there is no longer any reference to the biblical texts. The fact is that there is no true description, or positive definition, of the authentic experience of temporality. What does it mean to stand as an object among separate objects along the irreversible and continuous flow of time? As the “Letter on Humanism” says, it was precisely in the effort to reflect on authenticity that Heidegger discovered the “impossibility of overcoming” metaphysics and the lack of a language that prevented him from concluding *Being and Time*, and that constitutes the theme of his reflection later on. Anyhow, the mode in

which Paul relates to the faithful in Salonicco, to whom he writes, exemplifies a non-“objective” mode of relating to history. “You are our glory and our joy” (I Thessalonians 2:20) is not merely a rhetorical expression. Paul is aware that his mission’s success, and his very salvation, are bound up with the faithfulness to the gospel that the Thessalonians will preserve till the *parousia* (“Einleitung” 97–98). It is also true that neither *Being and Time* nor this lecture course gives clear or positive indications of authentic temporality. At least, we have no more indications than those concerning the overcoming of metaphysics—which in the lecture course is not called in this manner, though it is clearly anticipated in the Pauline (and Heideggerian) analysis of the modes of Christian experience and of its diversions. Paul insists above all on the significance of *thlipsis*, the affliction characteristic of the Christian life, starting with the “thorn in the flesh” of which the second Letter to the Corinthians speaks (II Corinthians 12:2–10), which prevents him, who once was “snatched up to heaven,” from boasting about his feeling of superiority to his Thessalonian audience. *Thlipsis* is not so much a specific kind of temptation that Christians should resist (the tradition often alludes to the temptation of the senses) or a suggestion of the saving function of suffering (here too, how much Christian tradition of “pain”!). Rather, it is watchfulness, as the *parousia* is seen not as an “objectively” announced fact but as the “thief in the night” who comes when we least expect him, because it is impossible to know the day or the hour:

II Cor. 12:2–10 gave us a glimpse of the self-world of Paul. The extraordinary plays no role in his life. Only when he is weak, when he endures the afflictions of his life, he can enter into close relationship with God. What is decisive is not mystic contemplation and its specific strains, but the endurance of weakness throughout his life.³

Here the reference to mysticism and the extraordinary experience expressed in the Letter to the Corinthians are decisive: the rest of the commentary and the observations concerning the meaning of the term *parousia* itself suggest that it is a matter of remaining faithful to the idea of Christ's return. This return is understood not as an objective or past event of which we would be certain once and for all (although Heidegger does not make this point explicitly, one might think that faith is not faith in the certainty of historical events, whose verified extraordinariness might ground belief in the announcement), nor as the given presence of mystical experience, nor as a predictable future occurrence located within the flow of time. The Christian language has changed the literal meaning of *parousia*, which in Greek means "presence." "The transformation of the concept, though, discloses another Christian life-experience. . . . For Christians, *parousia* means the reappearance of the Messiah who has appeared once before; a meaning that is not literally in the words."⁴ Waiting for the *parousia* does not entail waiting for a future event within linear time: "We never move in the pure analysis of consciousness from a future event to the sense of reference of the *parousia*."⁵

Here we glimpse, if you will, the effort to grasp in concepts the pure historicity of existence, which is not given naturally; instead, it must be conceptualized clearly in opposition to the metaphysical banality in which existence is always already thrown, as *Being and Time* says. Let me cite a few passages to illustrate these concepts: "The characteristic of the Christian life (which means, as we know, the authentic experience of temporality) is that it does not know the day or the hour of the *parousia*."⁶ "For the Christian life there is no certainty; constant uncertainty is the basic meaning of the factic life. The uncertain is not accidental, but rather necessary. . . . Those who say, 'Peace and Security!' are taken up by what life offers; they are in the dark in terms of knowledge of themselves."⁷ And a bit

further: "The meaning of temporality is basic to factic life-experience, just as much as it is basic to problems such as the eternity of God."⁸ It is not too difficult to recognize in the inauthentic experience of time the objectifying thought that forgets Being for the sake of beings, which later Heidegger will blame on metaphysics. In the 1920 lecture, the links to metaphysics are visible in the argument that Christianity has forgotten the original meaning of eschatology. "The present analysis has dealt with the core of the Christian life: the eschatological problem. Soon after the end of the first centuries the eschatological problem was concealed. Afterward, the original meaning of Christian concepts was not recognized. In contemporary philosophy too, the Christian formations of concepts are concealed behind the Greek attitude."⁹ Concealment (*Verdeckung*) and forgetfulness (*Vergessenheit*) are terms that the later Heidegger employs to speak of metaphysics as the forgetting of Being. Here they are merely a foreshadowing, which is sufficient to pose the question of how the forgetting of Christian eschatology and the forgetting of Being have been conjoined in the course of metaphysics, and of the extent to which they may be the same thing.

If we take literally, as I believe we should, these last passages from Heidegger's text, they lead not only to renewed questioning of Heideggerian philosophy's essential link to the Christian tradition but also to rethinking that tradition on the basis of the vision of metaphysics as the history of (the forgetting of) Being. The commentary to the Second Letter to the Thessalonians provides important indications to this effect, as it focuses on the Christian duty to wait for the *parousia* without mistaking the Antichrist in its multiple forms for the Messiah. These multiple forms may be traced back to the claim that the *parousia* cannot be identified with an "objective" historical event, a fact placed at a determinable instant of time. What in the end becomes clear is that after its origins, the history of Christianity for-

got the authentic meaning of eschatological waiting, and therefore can be taken as the history of the Antichrist. It is a history in the course of which the authenticity of the Christian message has been misunderstood, and that runs parallel to the history of the metaphysical forgetting of Being (perhaps not so much parallel to as intertwined with it; by the same token, onto-theology is only another name for metaphysics).

We can begin here an examination of the meaning of this link for Christianity, despite the synthetic way in which it has been studied so far, leaving for a future project the further analysis of its fundamental links to Heidegger's mature thought (from *Being and Time* to the writings following the "turning"). True, Heidegger's hypothesis that the history of Christianity is a "metaphysical" misunderstanding of the original meaning of the New Testament message is not in itself an original thesis. We might ask whether and to what extent it is not the pure and simple retrieval of modernist themes that were circulating in those years within Catholic thought and were condemned by Pope Pius X's *Encyclica Pascendi* in 1907. Here we can see, more in line with Heidegger's changing attitudes toward Catholicism, the basis of his polemical break from the scholastic tradition and from the "classical" metaphysics that this tradition intended to retrieve. This break was motivated by faithfulness to the original Christian experience, and was expressed in analogous terms to what was taking place in Catholic modernism.

Whatever the links that may be verified historically, even at the price of reducing considerably the originality of Heidegger's position, it is interesting to stress some of the implications of his commentary to the two epistles of Paul for a conception of faith and of Christian ethics. The insistence on the meaning of the "affliction" that must be endured without expecting to know the day or the hour has a theoretical significance that takes precedence over the

ethical, and touches the very meaning of faith and the theology in which it finds its inspiration. The Antichrist who continually tests the faithful and drives them to idolatrously identify the Messiah with figures who falsify his meaning refers to representational, objectifying thought (which Heidegger later on calls metaphysical thought), which, once it asserted itself in the Christian tradition, pushed into oblivion Christianity's authentic, original content. If Heidegger's reading of Paul is legitimate, these texts should tend not to pay excessive attention to the "theoretical" and descriptive content of biblical revelation. Every attempt to read revelation as a teaching on the nature and attributes of God falls into the same error of representational thought—the sin of objectifying metaphysics—against which we are called to recover the hearing of Being. The effort to conceive of Christianity and to live the Christian faith in the direction intended by Heidegger should probably start here, where it makes sense only if one understands that the Christian tradition is the main and most constant source of Heidegger's ontology, which one can do on the basis of writings such as the 1920 lecture course. In other words, if, as I believe, we must hypothesize (or, better, acknowledge) that Heidegger's philosophy is inseparable from its original reflection on the biblical message, this hypothesis does not merely clarify the historical (*historisch!*) sources of his philosophy or lead it back to Christianity as though in an ultimately reassuring conversion (as if to say that we may be Heideggerians without necessarily being against Christianity). Rather, we require an effect of reciprocity: not only does Paul help us clarify Heidegger, but Heidegger also proposes observations that, if taken seriously, guide us in a reinterpretation of the Christian tradition.

The separation of the early Christian faith from representational thought (the Antichrist)—cursorily elaborated by Heidegger in the context of his critique of onto-

theology—discloses the task of thinking of faith without “substance,” perhaps without dogma, and without a theology as a science. Heidegger’s polemical allusions to mysticism in the lecture course appear to take the same direction, for mysticism is viewed as yielding to the need for an “object” wherein to lose oneself (*Versenkung*), thus finding freedom from the weakness of existence, from *thlipsis*—which is the only authentic mode of waiting for the *parousia*.¹⁰ This is, too, the way in which we should read the links established in paragraph 28 between the Antichrist and the history of Christian dogmatic thought (110–112): “It is a profound problem for the history of spirit that the very concept of philosophy has to measure itself against the history of dogmatic thought, which has taken the perspective of representational thought criticized earlier.”¹¹

Regarding the ethics that might develop out of this kind of faith, the stress on weakness seems illuminating insofar as it discloses the meaning of authentic existence in relation to Being-toward-death (*Sein zum tode*)—of which *Being and Time* speaks. The meaning of Being-toward-death has been seen often (by myself, among others) as a key to authentic existence, in relation to the constitution of existence as a continuous texture of meaning and referrals: existence (*Dasein*) constitutes itself, albeit paradoxically, as an authentic totality only with a view to the possible impossibility of all possibility of life, which is constituted by the impending possibility of death. It is only by facing up to the possibility of death that the various, concrete possibilities of life appear in their true meaning as possibilities rather than hardening in their finality, and therefore let existence constitute itself as a dis-cursus endowed with meaning.

Heidegger’s reference to the weakness of life endured with faith, in contrast with mystic *Versenkung*, seems to allude to a vision that is so different as to make us suspicious of this interpretation of authentic existence. Perhaps the

authenticity made possible by the anticipatory decision for death cannot really be understood as an experience of meaning. Rather, *Dasein's* authentic existence has the character of lack and affliction, similarly to the Christian existence in Paul. In other words, *Dasein's* existence is predicated on the constant renunciation of the belief that existence is meaningful (*Sinnvoll*), and therefore is the weakness endured in waiting for the *parousia*. A few pages on in his text, Heidegger remarks that "In the Christian life, though, there is also an unbroken sense of life with spirituality that has nothing to do with the harmony of a life."¹² (Note that in *Being and Time* there is no mention of anything that could compare to the *parousia*. And yet Heidegger's insistence in his later writings on listening to Being has something to say on this matter.)

Heidegger's last word in his commentary to Paul can be placed in the framework I have outlined so far, namely the reference to the passage from the first Letter to the Corinthians, where Paul defines Christian existence in "negative" terms by means of the famous expression "*ὅς μέ*." If Christian existence is so careful not to allow itself to be defined by any positive content on the plane of faith or by any positive obligation on the moral plane (this too would be a form of idolatry, of Antichrist), it appears to resist all definition. Yet one attains an image of Christian existence that is faithful to Paul's teaching precisely by "leaving aside the substantive elements" of revelation.¹³ A Christian's life is radically historical, and therefore is determined by the cultural and vital frameworks into which he is thrown. However, while remaining totally immersed in his historical condition, the Christian remains faithful and waits for the Lord's return. This is how Heidegger understands the text of I Corinthians 7:29:

What I mean, my brothers, is this: time is short, and from now on married men should live as though

they were not married; those who weep, as though they were not sad; those who laugh, as though they were not happy; those who buy, as though they did not have possessions; those who deal in material goods, as though they were not fully occupied with them.

There is no alternative model of Christian life apart from the historical and always contingent involvement required of all the faithful; equally, there is no arcane knowledge of the mysteries that might be foreclosed to nonbelievers. There is no analogy with the mystery religions and initiation rites of the Greek tradition. "The initiate is to be removed from the context of life by means of manipulation. In a condition of rapture, God and the All are had in the present. The Christian knows no such 'enthusiasm,' but rather says 'let us be awake and sober.'"¹⁴ Although it does not appear explicitly here, Heidegger clearly has Husserl's term *epoché* in mind; on the following page he speaks of "phenomenological destruction," and soon afterward he alludes to Augustine and Luther, to suggest perhaps that, for himself, the idea that salvation might come from works rather than from faith is "Antichristian."

Is it possible to link to a profession of Lutheran Protestantism Heidegger's observations about the mode of conceiving and living Christian experience? We should at least keep in mind that in the subsequent elaborations of his thought Heidegger did not explicitly go in this direction. Moreover, his polemics against the Christian tradition and the history of dogmatic thought after the apostolic period increasingly blurred with the effort to overcome metaphysics and the onto-theology that always accompanies it. All this probably means that we would be led astray if we were to read these Heideggerian passages as a giving in to the motifs of Catholic modernism or as signs of the philosopher's transition from one Christian confession to an-

other. It would seem to be more accurate historically, and therefore more faithful to the development of Heidegger's thought, to ask whether here there are meaningful indications for more positive and productive links between the philosophical effort to overcome metaphysical objectivism and the search for a vision of Christianity. This vision would be capable finally of reflecting its own ecumenical sense on the planes of both dogma and ethics, as a way of listening to the new—postmodern—age of Being.

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Notes

Introduction

1. G. Vattimo, *Belief*, trans. Luca D'Isanto and David Webb (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1999).

1. *The God Who Is Dead*

1. See Schlechta, III, 853.
2. See for instance my *Il soggetto e la maschera. Nietzsche e il problema della liberazione*, 3rd ed. (Milan: Bompiani, 1999); *Dialogo con Nietzsche* (Milan: Garzanti, 2000); *Introduzione a Heidegger*, 14th ed. (Roma-bari: Laterza, 2000).
3. Martin Heidegger, *The Principle of Reason*, trans. Reginald Lilly (Bloomington: Indiana University Press), 94–102.

2. *The Teachings of Joachim of Fiore*

1. E. Trias, *La edad del espíritu* (Barcelona: Destino, 1994), 374.
2. See *Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, 5:112b–c; and *Expositio in Apocalysm*, f. 5b–c. These two works were edited in Venice in 1519 (*Concordia*) and 1527 (*Expositio*); both reprinted (photo. reprod.) by Minerva Verlag (Frankfurt, 1964).
3. H. De Lubac, *La posterité spirituelle de Joachim de Flore* (Paris: Lethielleux, 1979–1981).

4. Novalis, "Christendom or Europe," in *Philosophical Writings*, trans. M. M. Stoljar (Binghamton: State University of New York Press, 1997), 141.

3. *God the Ornament*

1. See chapter 10.
2. See the lecture on "Das Ding" in M. Heidegger, *Vortræge und Aufsætzte* (Pfullingen: Neske, 1954), esp. 178–81.

4. *History of Salvation, History of Interpretation*

1. To illustrate what I am trying to express, even though it may not serve as clarification, I can refer to a page of Heidegger's *Unterwegs zur Sprache* where he employs the colon with the same complex but not obscure sense: "Das Wesen der Sprache: Die Sprache des Wesens."

5. *The West or Christianity*

1. Novalis, "Christendom or Europe," in *Philosophical Writings*, trans. M. M. Stoljar (Binghamton: State University of New York Press, 1997).
2. Hans Blumenberg, *Die Legitimität der Neuzeit* (Suhrkamp: Frankfurt am Main, 1974).
3. Karl Löwith, *Meaning in History: The Theological Implications of the Philosophy of History* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1957).
4. See the discussion between Karl Löwith and Hans Blumenberg published in *aut aut* 22 (Nov.–Dec. 1987).
5. Novalis, "Christendom or Europe," 141.
6. Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, trans. T. Parsons (New York, Scribner, 1958).
7. Colin Campbell, *Romantic Ethics and Modern Consumerism* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1987).
8. A collection of essays by several authors, edited by myself and Pier Aldo Rovatti, under the title *Il pensiero debole*, was published in Milan by Feltrinelli (1983).
9. On these themes, I refer the reader to my book *The Transparent Society*, trans. David Webb (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992).

10. Novalis, "Christendom or Europe."

11. Ibid., 151.

12. "Perché non possiamo non dirci cristiani" is the title of a famous short essay by Benedetto Croce, published for the first time in 1942 and reedited in *Discorsi di varia filosofia*, vol. 1 (Bari: Laterza, 1945).

6. *The Death or Transfiguration of Religion*

1. For an illustration of the thesis of Dilthey, see chapter 10.

8. *The Christian Message and the Dissolution of Metaphysics*

1. Most recently, a philosophical reinterpretation of Dostoevsky from a Christian point of view has been proposed by Luigi Pareyson (*Dostoevskij, Filosofia, romanzo ed esperienza religiosa* [Torino: Einaudi, 1993]).

2. Wilhelm Dilthey, *Introduction to the Human Sciences. An Attempt to Lay the Foundation for the Study of Society and History*, trans. Ramon J. Betanzos (Detroit: Wayne State University Press), 229.

3. Ibid.

4. Ibid., 236.

5. Ibid.

6. Ibid., 308.

7. Ibid., 309.

8. Martin Heidegger, *Identität und Differenz* (Neske: Pfullingen, 1957); *Identity and Difference*, trans. J. Stambaugh (New York: Harper & Row, 1969).

10. *Heidegger and Christian Existence*

1. M. Heidegger, "Einleitung in die Phaenomenologie der Religion," in *Phänomenologie des religiösen Lebens, Gesamtausgabe*, II, vol. 60 (Frankfurt: Klostermann, 1995), 100. From now on cited in the text as "Einleitung," followed by the page number. (*Translations are mine—Tr.*)

2. Martin Heidegger, *Wegmarken* (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klostermann, 1976), 10.

3. M. Heidegger, "Karl Jaspers's Psychology of the World-

views," in *Pathmarks*, ed. W. McNeal (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 4.

4. "[II Cor. 12:2-10] gab uns einen Vorblick in die Selbstwelt des Paulus. Das Auserordentliche in seinem Leben spielt fuer ihn keiner Rolle. Nur, when er schwach ist, wenn er die Noete seines Lebens durchhaelt, kenn er in einen engen Zusammenhang mit Gott treten. . . . Nicht die mystische versenkung und besondere Anstrengung, sondern das Durchhalten der Schwachkeit des Lebens wird entscheidend." Heidegger, "Einleitung," 100.

5. "An diesem Begriffswandel zeigt sich die andersartige christliche Lebenserfahrung. . . . Für den Christen aber heisst parousia: 'das Wiedererscheinen des schon erschienen Messias,' was zunächst im wörtlichen Ausdruck nicht liegt." Ibid., 102.

6. "Wir kommens niemals durch die blosse Analyse des Bewusstseins von einen zukuenftigen Ereignis auf den Bezugsinn der parousia." Ibid.

7. "Fuer das christliche Leben gibt es keine Sicherheit; die staendige Unsicherheit ist auch das Charakteristische fuer die Grundbedeutendheiten des faktischen Lebens. Das Unsichere ist nicht zufaellig, sondern notwendig. . . . Die 'welche Friede und Sicherheit sagen' (5,3) . . . sind aufgegangen von dem, was das Leben bietet; sie sind im Dunkel, angesehen auf das Wissen um sich selbst." Ibid., 105.

8. "Der Sinn dieser Zeitlichkeit ist auch fuer die faktische Lebenserfahrung grundlegend, ebenso fuer Probleme wie etwa das der Ewigkeit Gottes." Ibid., 104.

9. "Die jetzige Betrachtung behandelt das Zentrum des christlichen Lebens: das eschatologische Problem. Schon zu Ende des ersten Jahrhunderts wurde das Eschatologische im Christentum verdeckt. Man verkennt in spaeterer Zeit alle urpruenglich christliche Begriffe. Auch in der heutigen Philosophie sind noch hinter der griechischen Einstellung die christliche Begriffsbildungen verborgen." Ibid., 104.

10. Ibid., 100.

11. "Es ist ein tiefes problem für die Geschichte des Geistes, das in der Begriff der Philosophie selbst sehr nahe angeht, aufzu-

hellen, die eben kritisierte vorstellungsmässige Einstellung genommen hat." Ibid., 111.

12. "Es gibt allerdings im Christlichen Leben auch ein ungebrochenen Lebenszusammenhang auf einer Stufe der Geistigkeit, was Nichts zu tun hat mit der Harmonie eines Lebens." Ibid., 120.

13. "das Inhaltliche beiseite lassen." Ibid., 116.

14. "Lasst uns wach sein und nüchtern." Ibid., 124.

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